The Helm Year

Volume 3 - Launch Pad Year Three, 2029-2030: What do I do when there is no easy answer? · spiral edition

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The Helm Year - Lesson Plan Book

A guide's book for Year Three of the Launch Pad, written so a learner can read every page.

A short opening note

This is a book for the guide who runs the third and final year of the Launch Pad - the year called The Helm. It is also a book any learner is welcome to read cover to cover. There is nothing in here to hide from you.

That is a promise with a shape. Everything in this book is safe and honest for a learner to read; nothing in it manages or manipulates anyone. Lines in "quotes" are things a guide might say aloud. Everything else is written for the guide to understand and hold - the reasons behind the moves, the care under the plan. When a note is written for the guide, it is still written to be read by a learner. There is no second, secret version.

One author's note on language: this book was written by Erin Stanley, who opened the studio and guided its first year. "The guide" means whoever is leading the studio, and this book says "they" throughout, because that will not always be the same person. Where the book says the guide is raising a small child, that is the shape of the year it was written for, named so the shape is owned; a later guide names their own shape in the same place. "You" sometimes means the guide and sometimes means the learner - the context always makes it clear which.

One more thing to say plainly at the start: this is the heaviest year in the three-year story, so the care around it is built up thickest. The material is real. It touches hard calls, mortality, shame, leadership, and, at the end, leaving. Which version a tribe runs, the lighter or the full, is decided by the guide before the year, and you will be told which. Inside it, every heavy day is yours to step out of, and the lighter path is always honorable, never a lesser version of the year. Held well, this year can change a person. Some will feel that, some won't yet, and both are true.

Part 1 - For everyone: what this year is

The year's question

The Helm is the year of **the hard call, and loving the life around it.**

The whole question of the year is this: *What do I do when there is no easy answer?* Not "how do I win." Instead: how do I face something that cannot be cleanly won? How do I make the call from my own principles, name what it costs, and not lose myself doing it? And how do I still love my actual life while I do?

The three years each carry their own question:

- **Origin - Who am I?** (Know your story.)
- **The Forge - What is worth solving?** (Find your work.)
- **The Helm - What do I do when there is no easy answer?** (Make the hard call, and love the life around it.)

The three years turn as a cycle rather than a ladder. Whichever year is running when you arrive is the one you start in, and you are not behind. You do not have to have done Origin or the Forge to start here. Your Log starts today, your Vineyard is named this week, and your Evidence File is built from any real proof you have. In the shared work you are a full Helm learner from the first morning. If you are not launching this year, the Council is yours all the same; the Launch is a rite for whoever is leaving, and the year's close is yours.

The journey

The Launch Pad is three years, three expeditions. The first year, Origin, is about **dreaming it**: who am I? The second year, The Forge, is about **building it**: what is worth solving? The Helm is the resolution. It is where you learn to make a real decision from your own principles, in the open, in front of your people, and still go home and love your life.

The arc runs self, then world, then the hard call. By now you know your story and you have found work worth doing. This year you learn four things. To reason when you truly cannot know the answer. To live with a hard decision. To lead the people beside you. To be mentored by adults who are further down the road. And one more: to choose life *because* you have looked at hard things, not by looking away from them.

The daily practice of this year is the **no-win scenario.** It is the practice of standing inside a situation that has no clean answer, long enough to reason from principle instead of reaching for the exit. It is the same muscle you have been building the whole time. In Origin you made small real choices in games. In The Forge you stood inside questions too big to close. This year you make the hard call inside a situation that cannot be won. Same muscle, one more turn.

Named plainly, the seven sessions are:

1. **The Mantle** - meet the feeling of not-belonging-yet, and take up what you will carry.
2. **No Easy Answers** - reason through real dilemmas from principle, out loud.
3. **The Ripple** - look downstream of a choice, and stay humble about what you can't see.
4. **The Stage** - feel a hard call from inside the lives it touches, through theatre.
5. **The Arena of Voices** - learn from adults further down the road, and how to be mentored well.
6. **The Bridge** - lead the people beside you, and be led.
7. **The Council** - make a hard call in the open, before your people.

The words this book uses

This studio has its own small vocabulary. None of it is a secret, so here it all is, before you meet any of it.

- **A quest.** One piece of work with a beginning and an end: a prompt, a case, a scene, a share. It is the unit you can say no to.
- **A session.** One of the year's seven stretches, each with its own question. Three to six weeks long, with a break after it.
- **Core.** Short for your core academics: the high-school credit work you have claimed, at your own pace, on your own days.
- **The settle.** The three slow breaths that open every guide day.
- **The way down.** Standing up and shaking it out after hard work, so your body can put the stress down.
- **The exit ramp.** The named place you can step out to, without asking, and come back from with nothing said.
- **The close-return.** The words the room says out loud after a heavy day, so your body hears that the heavy part is over. Always the same words; they are on the settle page.
- **The closing minute.** The three private questions at the end of an opening. Never written for the studio, never read by anyone.
- **The Captain's Log.** Your own record of your own life. Yours.
- **The Vineyard.** The thing you love that nobody ever makes useful.
- **The Work of the Day.** The one piece of the session's work the whole tribe does together that morning, named out loud at the start so you know what the day is for.

- **Your tribe.** The people in this studio with you.
- **Your crew.** Two things share this word. On a heavy day it is the one other learner who notices you and whom you notice; never a watch set on you. In the leadership work it is the people you lead and are led by.
- **The walk-in.** Two things share this word. The walk-in is the soft first stretch of a guide day, when the door is open and nothing is required. It is also what we call the quiet one-to-one conversations that happen inside that window, where the guide comes to one or two people rather than calling anyone over. "I'll catch you in the walk-in" means a conversation, not a meeting, and nothing in it is written down.
- **Fallow.** Deliberately empty. Fallow is a farming word: a fallow field is one you leave unplanted on purpose, because that is what makes it rich again. Fridays are fallow, and so is one whole week in the winter. Never earned, never filled.
- **A harvest.** The last stretch of a session, where you gather what the weeks grew and name what you got. It is yours to gather, and an empty harvest is a real harvest.
- **Witnessed.** Someone was there and saw it. Not watched, not assessed. Being witnessed is a gift and never a demand.
- **A re-thread.** Picking the year back up after a break. The first guide day back starts with it: where were you, where are you now, what came back changed. You are never restarting cold.
- **The pace question.** The guide asking whether the plan still matches the speed your real life is running at.
- **The re-ask.** The guide asking, out loud, *is this still yours?* It is not a mood check and it is not rhetorical. "No" and "I don't know" are both real answers, and it gets asked at points in the year where there is still time to act on the answer.
- **Open Waters.** The loose three weeks after the Council: expeditions, your own projects, credit close-out, and real rest.
- **The no-win scenario.** The year's daily practice: standing inside a situation that cannot be cleanly won, long enough to choose from principle instead of grabbing the exit. The name is borrowed from an old Star Trek story about a training test built so nobody can pass it. In the story the hero cheats the test; that part is the bait, not the lesson.
- **The hard call.** A decision where every path costs something real. Making one well: from principle, cost named, without losing yourself.
- **The Mantle.** A real object you take up in the first session and carry all year. It stands for "I am someone who can hold a hard call." At the end you decide to keep it or leave it; both are true.
- **The Evidence File.** Real proof you have already done hard things, pulled from your own record. It lines the Mantle, so the proof is in the pocket when not-belonging shows up.
- **The Reasoning Standard.** Five questions a hard call must answer, none of which is "what is the right answer."
- **A real dilemma, and a rationalized wrong.** A real dilemma has two real goods pulling against each other. A rationalized wrong has one, dressed as two.

- **Steelman.** Saying the side you disagree with so well its holder would say “yes, that’s it.” You may not argue your own side until you have.
- **Forum Theatre.** A hard-call scene is acted out; anyone can stop it, step in, and try a different choice. Deliberation you can see.
- **De-roling.** Stepping out of a part: say your name, three true things about your real life, prop down, shake out, feel what is under you. It closes a role. It never closes real grief; the closing minute does that.
- **The second adult.** On the deep days of the three heaviest sessions, a second adult whose only job is to leave with the learner who needs to leave. No second adult that week, the heavy block waits.
- **The Council.** The year’s harvest: a hard call made in the open, in front of your people, by reasoning together. Not a debate. A debate has a winner. It sits twice, once with the tribe alone and once with your people in the room, and both are the Council.
- **The Third Chair.** An empty chair between two hardened sides, holding four questions: what is each side protecting, is the “or” real or inherited, what would honor both, and if nothing can, which do we choose and what do we grieve.
- **The steward of the absent.** The one Council seat whose only job is “who is affected by this who is not in the room?”
- **The Launch.** The rite at the end of three years for a learner leaving: the ending named, a threshold crossed in front of your people, the door left unlocked from your side. Nobody is ever pulled back through it.
- **The Star Chart.** The map of where you have been, handed to you at the Launch, at the moment you must steer by it alone.

What you make and carry

Three things belong to you this year, and one of them you carry out the door for the rest of your life.

The Captain’s Log. This has been yours since your first day here, whichever year that was. It is your private voice, your record of what you met and what you carried. A guide never reads it to grade you or check on you; it was never surveillance and it never will be. It is yours every day, not only at the end: it goes where you say, home or a place here only you open, and no copy is ever made, because the moment there is a copy somebody else is holding your life. At every year’s close the handoff is said aloud, and if you leave, you carry it out the door.

The Mantle. This year you take up a Mantle: a role, a way of standing, an “I am someone who can hold a hard call.” You take it up in the first session, you wear it into the leadership work and the Council, and at the very end you decide, on your own, whether to keep it or leave it. Both choices are true. The choosing is the point.

The Vineyard. This is the thing you love that has nothing to do with the curriculum: the instrument, the trail, the craft, the friendship, the game, the album on the floor. It was named on your first day here as the quiet twin of the Captain's Log, and by now it has roots. It is never made useful, because the moment it is useful it stops being a Vineyard. No one grades it, no one turns it into a lesson, no one asks you to reflect on it. At the Launch, the one small thing you leave for the room *can* be your Vineyard-thing, if you choose; it can also be anything else, and nobody will ask. Loving your life is not a footnote to making hard calls. It is what the hard calls are *for*.

When, and this is the one part that is required. Making time for something you love is a requirement of this programme. Not a particular thing, not a certain number of hours, and not anything you hand in. The requirement is that the time is in your week and that something you love is in the time. Friday is already yours and is the obvious home; the tail of a Tuesday is another. Nobody ever checks what you did with the time. The only question anyone will ever ask is *is the time there*. The requirement binds us to keep making room for it. It does not bind you to fill the room.

The promises (the six refusals)

Underneath everything, there is a floor of promises. Nothing in the Launch Pad is allowed to break these. In plain words:

1. **No grades or scores anyone but you can see.** Your progress is yours. High-school credit is the one honest exception, and it is explained at the end of this Part.
2. **No ranking and no leaderboards.** You are never stacked against the person next to you. A parent linked to your account can see which of your own goals you have finished, and that is the whole of what anyone else sees. If that ever stops being exactly true, you will be told before it changes, not after.
3. **No one deposits the answers into you.** You make meaning here; the guide holds questions and walks with you, and does not hand you a finished answer.
4. **No imposed deadlines.** You set your own pace. "I didn't get to it" is honored, not punished.
5. **Your worth is not your output.** A quest you abandoned and learned from counts as much as one you finished. Doing more does not make you worth more.
6. **No surveillance.** The data of your life belongs to you, not to the school. This promise is about a short list of what gets written down about you, and the list is at the end of this Part so you can check it.

And one more, which sits on top of the six:

You may refuse the structure itself. If you decline a whole quest, you are fully honored. You are not quietly marked down as a failure or an opt-out. Your no is real.

Where your no reaches, and where it stops

Here is the edge of that last promise, said now rather than discovered later.

Your no covers your own work. A quest, a case, a role, a scene, a share, a whole session, this entire structure. It lands the moment you say it, it costs you nothing, and nobody can overrule it.

It does not cover how you treat the people in the room with you. That is not a deadline and it is not output. It is the floor that makes everything else here safe for the other people in the room, and it is the one place in this programme where something can actually be taken from you. The studio's agreements run that floor, and they have their own ladder: a Pause, then a Stop, then a Strike. You will meet it in your first week, and you will help write the agreements it rests on. The count clears at the start of every year, so nothing from last year walks in with you.

So, in one line: **the agreements are about how we treat each other. The promises are about whether you do the work.**

Declining a quest is never a Pause. A Pause is never a judgement on your work, your pace, or whether you are keeping up. If anyone ever runs those two together, they have got it wrong, and you can say so out loud and point at this page.

And if you do not sign. You are in the room anyway, and that was never the price of being here. The agreements still run for you, and here is the honest reason rather than a convenient one: they are not holding you to your word, because you did not give it. They are holding the room safe for the people in it with you. You can tell us the agreements are not yours. You cannot be outside the floor, because **the floor is not about you.**

How we work: the week

The studio day runs through the morning, 9:00 to 1:00. Across the week, two mornings are guide days and two are your own.

- **Guide days (Tuesday and Thursday).** The guide runs the studio with you. The order of the morning is below, and it is the same every time. What differs this year is the middle: Tuesday's work is lighter, and Thursday holds the week's one deep block. That is on purpose. One deep block a week is the shape every year of the Launch Pad has run, and

the guide is here all four mornings this year, so the lighter day is not a lighter guide; whether both guide days could carry a deep block in this year is the guide's call before the year, and this book will say which.

- **Your-own days (Monday and Wednesday).** You run your own morning: your reading, your core academics, your personal project, and the session's writing. Nobody is steering but you. This year the guide is in the room with you on your own days, working alongside you on their own things: planning, reading, their own Log. They are not watching; they are working, and a guide at the next table who does not look up is the point. The midday check-in still happens, around noon, as a real conversation and not a glance across the room. If you need them before noon, you say so. You are genuinely running your own hours and you are never alone in the building. Both of those are true at once.
- **The fallow day (Friday).** Protected. Never earned, never filled, never converted back into work. It is for rest, play, friendship, and making things for no reason. This is not a reward for finishing. It is practice for a whole life. And it is binding: it does not get eaten to cover a busy week. It is for you and for the guide both.

A guided morning, start to finish

Guide days run 9:00 to 1:00. The order is the same on both days, so you never walk in wondering what today is. What changes between Tuesday and Thursday is the middle block.

Time	What happens
9:00 - 9:25	**The walk-in.** Door open, nothing required. Put your things down, make tea, talk or don't. The guide is here and will come find one or two people for a quiet one-to-one.
9:25 - 9:35	**The settle, then the circle.** Three breaths, the same words every time. Then one round of "how are you, really?" You may pass.

Time	What happens
9:35 - 10:50	**The Work of the Day.** Tuesday: the day's no-win question, then the lighter work - group challenges, theatre as play, leadership practice, planning an outing. Thursday: the week's one deep block. On the heaviest day of the three heaviest sessions there is a second adult in the room - in No Easy Answers and the Stage that day is a Tuesday, so the deep block and the lighter day trade places; in the Council it is the Thursdays and the public sitting - and you will know which days those are before they come. This is the part that changes week to week. The rest of this table does not.
10:50 - 11:00	**The way down.** Stand, shake it out, step outside, water. Then we eat.
11:00 - 11:40	**The Table.** We eat together. You bring your own lunch. On a heavy day this is the come-down, and nothing is asked of you at it.
11:40 - 12:40	**Hands and each other.** Making, building, rehearsing, an errand, a project with somebody else. Different from the morning's work on purpose: the body works and the talking gets easy. On Tuesdays this is a fine home for your Vineyard if you want it there; nobody asks.
12:40 - 1:00	**The close.** One light thing, then your closing minute, then you go.

The times are honest rather than strict. Most days drift ten minutes. The order never drifts.

The Table

Every guide day has a shared meal in the middle of it. Here is exactly how it goes.

You bring your own lunch. On ordinary days the studio does not provide the food.

It is still a shared table rather than a lunch break. We stop, sit down together, and the guide sits and eats with you. The forty minutes is for being a group of people who eat together, not for getting through food on the way to the next thing.

You sit wherever you want. Seats are not assigned, and nobody's seat is kept from last week.

You do not have to eat. Presence is the whole requirement here, never consumption. If you are fasting, or observing, or not hungry, or food is a hard thing for you right now, you sit with us and that is full participation. Nobody watches anybody's plate, and you never owe anyone an explanation for what is or is not on yours.

If you arrive late, come in and sit down. Nothing restarts, and nobody asks where you were in front of the room.

On the one day a year when there *is* shared food, the feast after the Council, tell the guide what you cannot eat, once, whenever you know it. Planning around it is the guide's job rather than yours to work around. That day the studio provides the base of the meal, and bringing a dish is never required. If you want what the studio brings to stand as yours, say so to the guide once, privately, and it will. Nobody at the table will know the difference, and nobody will ask.

Sometimes a guest speaker is with us across the Table. They eat with us by the same rule, and the guide tells them the shape before they come. You never owe a guest a performance of gratitude for sitting with us. Being at the table is the thanks.

The circle: "how are you, really?"

Right after the settle, every guide day, we go around once. The question is "how are you, really?" and it means the real answer rather than the automatic one.

Here is how it goes. The guide asks, and answers first, honestly and briefly. Then it goes around in order, so nobody is picked on and nobody has to volunteer. One or two sentences each is plenty. "Tired." "Good, actually." "I don't want to say today." Those are complete answers.

You can always pass. Say "pass" and it moves on, with no follow-up and no note taken. Passing is not a smaller answer. A person who passes has been round the circle the same as everyone else.

Nobody fixes what you say here unless you ask. Advice that arrives unasked is not help, so the circle starts from being heard.

But you can ask, and you can ask the room. "Does anyone know what to do about this?" is a completely normal thing to say in a circle, and so is "I just wanted to say it, I don't want to talk about it." Both are answers to the same question, and the question is yours: **do you want this held, or do you want it worked?** Say which and the room will follow you. Six people who know you is not a smaller resource than one guide, and some things a seventeen-year-old knows better than any adult in the building.

If you would rather not ask in front of everyone, that is equally fine. Say so, or say nothing and catch the guide afterwards.

It takes a few minutes. It is not a check-up, and nothing said in it is written down.

Who else is in the room

There are a handful of you and one of me, and this year I am here all four mornings. My child is in Vibrant Life Tots, down the hall, with their own teacher, on the mornings we meet; they are not in the studio. The first year they were in the room with us, worn; the second year they were with childcare on the two mornings I was here. This is the first year you get the whole of my week.

On the heaviest days of the three heaviest sessions there is also a second adult in the room. In No Easy Answers and the Stage that day is a Tuesday, so the deep block and the lighter day trade places; in the Council it is the Thursdays and the public sitting. They are not here for me. They are here for the room, so that if one of you needs to step out, somebody can go with you and I never have to choose between the room and you. If they cannot be there one week, the lighter version of the day runs and the deep version waits. You will know who they are before the first heavy week. They are another trained adult, never one of you.

And the same plain thing as every year: if you ever need all of me, a hard day or a conversation that cannot be interrupted, say so. There is nothing to hand off; you have me.

Arriving late, stepping out, coming back

Arriving late. Walk in. There is no procedure and nothing restarts. If the circle is going, join where it has got to, or pass. If the settle is going, sit down and pick it up on the next breath. Nobody will ask you in front of the room where you were. If something made you late and you want the guide to know, catch them at the Table.

Coming back after stepping out. The soft parts of the day are named so you know where the easiest way back in is: the walk-in, the Table, and the hands block after it. You can come back at any moment, including the middle of a hard one. The soft seams are just the ones where nothing has to be said at all. Nobody says anything to you when you come back. Not even “glad you’re back.” You pick up a plate or pick up a tool and you are in.

On a heavy day, stepping out works the same way, and the exit is named again that morning for that room. If the second adult comes out with you, you do not have to talk to them. They are there so that nobody is alone with a hard thing. During the Council there is also the pass signal, which hands the floor back at no cost and with no explanation.

The Log, captured however you hold it

You keep the Captain's Log in whatever form is true to you. Written in a notebook. Spoken aloud and recorded. Drawn. Dictated. Typed. Told to a scribe who writes it down for you. No form is the lesser Log. The point is that you are keeping your own record, not that it looks a certain way.

Where it lives. Your Log can go home with you, or stay here somewhere only you open, or both, and you can change your mind any time. If you want it to stay here, say so and nobody asks why. It is not kept in the Compass or on any school computer, and no copy is made.

When you write in it. There is no Log time and nobody will ever call one. The walk-in, right after your closing minute, your own mornings, and Friday if you want it are all open rather than expected. A record you have to feed every day stops being a record and becomes a chore, and **there are supposed to be days you skip.** A Log with gaps in it is not a failed Log; it is what an honest one looks like.

One rule about this, and it is for the guide as much as you: **nobody writes on a bell.** We will never all sit down and write at the same time, because the moment that happens, everyone can see who is writing and who is not, and the only thing that makes this yours is that nobody is watching.

How "no" works here

You may decline anything. **Your no takes effect the moment you say it, and it is not conditional on explaining yourself.** This is called **decline-with-reasoning**, and here is the honest shape of it.

You can say no to any quest, any case, any role, any share, and the no lands straight away. Nothing is held up while you find words.

The reasoning is still owed. Two things about that, and they matter equally. **It is owed to your tribe, not to the guide.** You are in a room with other people whose work and plans move around yours, so they get to know where you stand. It is not a toll you pay an adult for permission. And **it is not owed in the moment.** "I don't know yet, and I'll come back to you" is a real answer. Take a day. Take the week. Work it out in your Log first and come back when you have it. A reason you had to produce on the spot is not thinking, it is pressure.

The guide may ask you an honest, curious question about it, the way a friend might. But the guide **has a voice, never a veto.** The guide cannot overrule your reason, and cannot require you to have one ready. The question is a mirror, not a test you can fail.

There is one place where even the curious question is set aside: anything to do with official papers and government forms. There, an honest reason for declining might reveal something private about your legal situation that a guide has no business knowing. So on that one surface, your no needs no reason at all.

Meeting a hard thing with the ordinary supports. Twice this year, in two of the lighter sessions, the Ripple and the Arena of Voices, you may choose to meet a hard thing with the ordinary supports instead of the full net: the guide present, the exit there, the visible crew turned down. It is offered, you choose it by name, and it is never sprung on you. The floor's availability never goes down; only how loudly it is announced. It is never pressed on a learner already carrying more than enough, because the point is an ordinary-sized hard thing met with ordinary support, not a wound made on purpose.

The settle

Every guide day opens with a short, body-first way in, and there is a matching way down when something gets heavy. This is fixed, and it is yours to keep for life.

- **The way in (the settle).** Three slow breaths with the out-breath longer than the in-breath (roughly four counts in, six counts out), feet flat, one hand where you feel your breath. The guide paces it out loud, the same way every time. The out-breath is what tells your body it is safe to settle. No app, no playlist, no special frequency. Just a human voice, used the same way on purpose. It is the same three moves every day, all three years, because the sameness is what lets it become yours. When you are forty and something cracks you open, this is a way to come home to yourself.

- **The way down.** After hard work stirs the body up, you stand, shake it out, take a short walk, move the activation *through* the body before sitting back down. If standing or walking is not yours, any movement that is - shaking out your hands, rolling your shoulders, rocking - does the same work. You cannot metabolize a stress spike sitting still. On heavy days there is a short one in the middle of the work too: thirty seconds, feet on the floor or hands on the chair, look around the room, one breath.

- **The way out (the exit ramp).** There is a named place you can step out to, set up in the first week. You do not have to ask. And there is a designed way back in during a soft part of the day, with no scene, no acknowledgment demanded. Stepping out and coming back costs you nothing. This is the room holding a door open for you, never the room watching you for a fall.

- **The way back (the close-return).** After a day that went somewhere heavy, the room says out loud that the heavy part is over, so your body hears it and not just your head. These words do not change either:

> *"That was then. This is now. Look around and name one thing you can see. You're in this room, and the hard part is behind you."*

It sounds almost too simple to do anything. It works because a body that has been inside a hard thing for an hour does not automatically notice that the hour ended, and being told, in words, is how it notices. Solo version, for the rest of your life: *that was then, this is now, and I'm here.*

One more close belongs to this year, because this year you wear other lives on a stage. **De-roling** closes a role: say or sign your own name, three true things about your real life, prop down, shake out whatever part of you moves, feel what is under you. It says "that wasn't me." The close-return and the closing minute close a real feeling the role opened: "that was me, and I carry it, and I'm still here." They are kept strictly separate, because real grief is never something a learner is asked to put down like a costume.

The closing minute

At the close of an opening - a dilemma reasoned, a life tried on, a hard conversation - you take a quiet minute and cross back through three fixed questions. They are always the same, in the same order:

1. **What did I meet?**
2. **What do I carry back?**
3. **What's different in me now - even a little?**

That is the whole practice. It is spoken or held in your head, never written down for the studio, never read by anyone. It is yours. It runs at the close of every guide day, light days included, because a practice used only on heavy days never becomes the one you reach for at forty.

Reach for the real answer. Taking the first thing that comes to mind and moving on makes this worth almost nothing. Staying in the question for a whole minute and letting something come up makes it worth a great deal, and **something almost always comes up, if you stay open long enough to hear it.** That takes a kind of nerve. It is the same nerve the rest of this year asks for.

"I don't know yet" is a real answer, not because the question has no answer, but because sometimes the true one has not surfaced, and naming that beats manufacturing something to have said. "Nothing's different, and I'm steadier for having looked" is also true and complete, because steadier is a change.

But you will know the difference between *I don't know yet* and *I didn't look*. Nobody else ever will. Nobody reads this, nobody asks about it, and no one can tell from the outside whether you reached or shrugged. **This is the one practice here that runs entirely on your own honour**, and what you do with a quiet minute when nobody is checking is worth knowing about yourself. The whole point is that you can run it on yourself for the rest of your life, at a kitchen table at 2 a.m., with no guide in the room.

The one adult outside the room

There is one adult, outside the studio, you can always talk to. You will know who they are and how to reach them in the first week, before you ever need them.

One honest line about breaks, said now. When the studio is on a break - the short ones between sessions, Thanksgiving, the two weeks at winter, and the summer - the guide is not reachable. A break is rest and reset for them too, and the book protects that the same way it protects your Friday. The one adult outside the room is reachable across every break, the same as always. And if you are ever in danger, or someone else is, **988** is free, open all day and all night, and you can call or text it from anywhere. Nobody here will ever be upset that you used it.

And this is the honest shape of privacy, said on the first day rather than saved for the moment it matters. Almost everything stays here. Your Captain's Log, nobody reads. Your closing minute is never written down by anyone.

Here is what doesn't. If the guide believes you are in danger, that someone is hurting or neglecting you, or that something is going on that is bigger than a studio morning can hold, they will bring in real help. That includes talk of suicide or self-harm, abuse or neglect, something going wrong with eating, a crisis with drugs or alcohol, a panic or a flashback they cannot reach you through, a threat to someone else, or something that keeps going and is getting in the way of your life.

Those are two different things and they have different consequences, so both get named. **Abuse or neglect is a report**, and in Idaho the guide is required by law to make it. **Everything else on that list is a hand-off**, which means they stop the session work and help you get to someone trained, you will be told who, and you get a say in which one and when.

In most of those cases they will also call your parent or guardian, and they will tell you they are making the call. The one exception is if your parent or guardian is the person hurting you. Then the call goes to the state rather than to them.

That is the whole list. It is not one secret trapdoor, and the guide will never go looking for a reason to use it. **What they know is only what you chose to tell them.** None of this is breaking trust. It is what care actually looks like.

What gets written down about you

Short answer: very little, and you can read all of it.

- **Your Captain's Log and your Vineyard.** Yours. Nobody reads them. No copy is kept.
- **Your closing minute.** Never written down at all, by anyone.
- **Your witnessed work** - your reasoned position on a hard case, a monologue if you perform it, the Council board, your Evidence File, your next-step plan. The guide sees what you bring into the room, and so do the people you choose to show. That is what bringing it means.
- **The guide's own notes.** A short practical record: attendance, your pace and your credit plan, and a factual note if there is ever a safety event, meaning what happened, what they did, and who they called. A safety note never contains what you wrote or said about your own life.
- **The cards from the first session.** If you write one, it is read once in the guide's voice with no name, and then it is gone. Nobody keeps them or matches a hand to a name.
- **A recent loss, if you choose to say.** Before the one scene in the year that touches death directly, the guide will ask you, one to one and never in the circle, whether there is a recent loss you would want that day planned around. You can decline to say, and nothing is written either way.
- **If you are matched with a mentor.** The guide can see that contact exists and how often, never what it says. You, your parent and the mentor sign the boundaries together. Your parent is told who any guest speaker is and when they come.
- **Your Growth Record, in the Compass.** The one record here that is built to leave with you. It works differently from everything else on this list, so it has its own section below.
- **The agreements record, if you ever reach a Stop.** Our studio agreements run on a ladder: a Pause, then a Stop, then a Strike. The Stop and the Strike are the two rungs that make paper. A Stop note says what happened and goes home the same day, you fill it out with your guide, and the line about coming back is yours in your own words. A Strike letter lists the dates of the three Stops. Your character contract is yours, in your handwriting, and a copy stays with Jenna, who runs the school, while you are working it. All of it records a choice and never a judgement about who you are, the count clears at the start of each year, and none of it goes on a transcript or travels with your Growth Record.
- **What is never kept.** Scores. Rankings. Assessments of your character written by anyone but you. Any note about you that you have not read. Any file that follows you past this year.

You can ask to read anything written about you, at any time, and the guide will show you. If you think a note is wrong, say so, and it gets corrected. That includes a Pause, a Stop or a Strike: if you think a call was wrong, say so, and it can come off - off the note and off the count. You do not have to be calm about it. A learner who is angry at an unfair call is giving us information, not failing a condition.

That is the whole of it. “No surveillance” is a promise about this list, and the list is short on purpose.

The Growth Record, the Launch, and whether any of this counts on paper

You are sixteen to eighteen, so a fair question about any year of your life is whether it counts on paper. Here is the straight answer.

The Compass holds a record called your **Growth Record**, and the whole design of it is that you own it and the studio does not. The app is a lens, not a vault: you hold the keys from the first day, and a guide is a guest whose access ends when the relationship does, which for a launching learner is the Launch. A school cannot lose, withhold or hold hostage a record it never held in the first place.

It has two faces, and you control which one anybody sees.

- **The Journey view** is the whole trail, in order, with the slow parts and the stalls in it. It stays private. It is yours. Reading it at the start of the Launch is your invitation: alone, or with the guide if you want company.
- **The Portrait view** is the one you would hand a college, an employer or a programme. It is framed as what you can actually do, and **you choose what goes into it, piece by piece.** Nobody assembles your Portrait for you, and nobody sends it anywhere without you.

One rule holds across both, and it is built into the thing rather than promised about it: growth here is only ever shown as **movement compared to your own earlier self.** Never a grade. Never a score. Never set beside another learner.

And the honest limit, which you should hear from us rather than discover. The part that lets the record physically leave - a real export, readable by a human, held in your hands - **is not finished yet.** It is being built. Until it exists, nobody walks the Launch, because a ceremony that hands you something that is not there is not a ceremony. That is a rule the programme put on itself before any learner was in the room.

The Launch, and what is promised. If you are leaving at the end of this year, the Helm's last session closes, and then, in the third week of Open Waters, on a day set with you and never the last day, the Launch: a rite in three movements, where the ending is named out loud, you decide what to do with the Mantle, you leave one small thing for the room, and you step over a real threshold into a circle of adults who receive you as one. That is promised, and so is this: the Launch is built to be sad as well as glad, on purpose. It names that this was your home and that you are leaving it, and holds that without hurrying. If no family is in the room, the tribe is your people, said now and not on the day. Two things are conditional, and you should hear them now. The Launch cannot be walked until the Growth Record export exists. And the deep version of each heavy session runs only when a second adult is in the room; otherwise the lighter version runs, and that is the floor working, not you missing something. What is never conditional: the door stays unlocked from your side, nobody will call you back, and a launched learner who never returns is a success.

Two more things, said plainly. High-school credit is tracked separately, and it is the one record other people read as a routine matter, which is the honest exception to the first promise; if this is your last year, the guide will walk the credit close-out with you rather than leave it to the last week. And a transcript from a studio like this one is not yet a thing every college recognises; the bridge to dual enrollment is real work and we will do it alongside you rather than pretending it is already finished.

Part 2 - For the guide: teaching this year

The shape of the year, and naming the destination on day one

The Helm runs the full Vibrant Life year, mid-August to late May, on the school's calendar rather than a tidy one of its own, and it takes the same shape as Origin: seven sessions with a break between each, thirty-one weeks of session work, plus the three-week Open Waters tail, for thirty-four program weeks in all. The sessions are **not** equal lengths. They are set by where the breaks fall. The last session is the harvest, and for a leaving learner it flows into the Launch.

The Helm 2029-2030. A program week is Monday to Thursday: two guide mornings (Tuesday and Thursday), two the learners run themselves (Monday and Wednesday), and Friday fallow.

Session	Dates	Weeks
S1 The Mantle	Aug 13 - Sep 6	4
session break	Sep 10 - 13	
S2 No Easy Answers	Sep 17 - Oct 18	5
session break	Oct 22 - 25	
S3 The Ripple	Oct 29 - Nov 15	3
Thanksgiving	Nov 19 - 23	
S4 The Stage	Nov 26 - Dec 13	3
Winter break	Dec 17 - 28	
S5 The Arena of Voices	Dec 31 - Feb 7	6
session break	Feb 11 - 14	
S6 The Bridge	Feb 18 - Mar 28	6
session break	Apr 1 - 4	
S7 The Council	Apr 8 - May 2	4
Open Waters (flex tail)	May 6 - May 23	3

Five Mondays inside sessions are holidays: Labor Day (Sep 3) in S1, the second Monday of October (Oct 8) in S2, Veterans Day observed (Nov 12) in S3, MLK Day (Jan 21) in S5, and Presidents Day (Feb 18) on S6's first day. A Monday here is a self-run morning rather than a

guided one. Two guide days are holidays: Election Day, Tue Nov 6, in S3, and New Year's Day, Tue Jan 1, in S5's first week as projected. Whether the studio observes Election Day is decided before S3 opens.

These dates take Origin's 2027-2028 shape and begin it on Monday, August 13, 2029, around that year's real Thanksgiving week. They are a projection. One thing the real calendar will move: as printed, S5 opens on Monday, December 31 with New Year's Day on its first Tuesday, so expect the winter break a week later. Jenna, who runs the school, sets the real dates. Confirm them before anything is printed for a family.

The sessions below are cut to these weeks. Where the calendar gave a session more weeks than its plan, the extra went to air (a threshold week at the front of the Mantle; the Bridge learning the Council's form at low stakes), to the year's one fallow week, named as such in the Arena of Voices, and in one case to nothing: the Bridge's fourth week is left unplanned on purpose. Where the calendar gave fewer, the Stage runs in three weeks with the death scene on its second Tuesday and a held week after it, and the Council runs in four because its form was learned in March. Nothing was added because a week existed.

Every session ends into a break, so every session carries the same two seams. On the last guided day, the carry-out: the pace question, the harvest, and the closing minute at session scale. On the first guided day back, the re-thread. The re-ask is rarer and is asked three times, where there is still time to act on the answer: at the winter break, which is the Stage's last guided day; after the Arena of Voices; and on the year-close day. The agreements are open for reopening at every session's close too - say so on the last guided day, every time, so the handle is real and not only promised in week one.

On the very first day, name the destination out loud. This is the single most important framing move of the year:

> *"In May you will sit with your people and make a hard call in the open. We call it the Council. Some of you will then go out the door into your own lives - that's the Launch. Everything between now and then is getting ready to sit in that chair and mean it."*

No week count in the line: the count is not settled, and a date that moves is a promise broken. Once the mountain is named on day one, every session becomes a rung toward it. The reasoning work is how the captain thinks. The empathy work is how the captain feels the cost. The mentorship work is learning the terrain from those who walked it. The leadership work is how the captain holds the room. Give them the mountain first, and the whole year points somewhere.

Three threads run through the whole year and give it a spine:

1. **The destination**, named day one (the Council, and the Launch).
2. **The Mantle**, one physical object taken up in Session 1 and carried to the end.
3. **The Vineyard**, the un-useful joy, tended for years, ripening now.

The year's daily frame: the no-win call

The daily ritual of The Helm is the no-win scenario. It opens every guide day after the settle and the circle, because you cannot stand inside something that cannot be won while nobody in the room knows you are tired. Name it plainly as the same muscle the learners have built all along: small choices in Origin, standing inside big questions in The Forge, and now the hard call inside a situation that cannot be cleanly won.

The famous move in the old story - reprogram the test, beat the unbeatable - is the bait, not the lesson. For near-adults months from the real world, the deeper truth is this: the test is not whether you can always find the clever third option. It is who you are when there is no third option. Sometimes the freighter dies: sometimes there is no option where nobody loses something. So teach both halves. Half the wisdom is finding the third door when it is really there. The other half is knowing when there isn't one, choosing anyway from principle, naming the cost, and not losing yourself carrying it. The highest thing this whole three-year arc can produce is not "the learner found the clever way out." It is: the learner faced something that could not be won, made the hard call from principle, named what it cost, and did not lose themselves doing it.

The safety floor, fullest here

This year has the heaviest material in the whole program, so the floor is built up thickest. Do not treat the floor as the brake on honesty. The floor is what lets the room go to hard places and come back. Honest-and-held changes a person; honest-and-abandoned wounds them. The whole difference is that one word: held.

The floor has these parts, and they are non-negotiable:

- **The settle, the way down, the close-return, the closing minute.** Described in full in Part 1; the learner reads the same words you do. Every heavy day opens with the settle (settle the room before you stir it), has a short way down in the middle of the work, and ends with the close-return said in its fixed words, so people land back in the present. Fix your own wording for the settle in the first week, write it down, and do not improve it, because the sameness is the medicine: a settle improvised fresh never becomes the reflex a body drops into, and if it goes stale to you, that is it working. Run the closing minute at

the close of every guide day, light days included; “take your closing minute” is the whole prompt, and you never ask what came up. A tired guide cuts these first because they feel like overhead. They are not overhead. They are the floor.

- **Stepping out and back.** There is a named place a learner can go to, set up in week one, and they never have to ask. Coming back in costs nothing - they slip back during a soft moment, no scene, no acknowledgment demanded.

- **A crew that holds each other.** On heavy days every learner is paired with one other learner who simply notices them. Frame it as a crew, always - never “assigned to watch you flood.” A crew keeps the person at the centre the one steering. A watch set on someone turns them into the thing being watched, and the room into the hero of their story. Keep them the hero.

- **A second adult present for the heaviest sessions.** Three sessions carry material heavy enough that one adult cannot both hold the room’s deliberation and catch the one learner quietly going under. On the deep day of those three, a second adult is required in the room - not for childcare, but as a second pair of eyes whose only job is to leave with the learner who needs to leave, at that learner’s pace, so you never have to choose between the room and the wound. The three are Session 2 (the heaviest dilemmas), Session 4 (the death scene in *Our Town*), and Session 7 (the public Council). The second adult is another trained adult: a co-op parent who has done the safety briefing, or another adult freed for that hour, never one of the learners. Name it as a precondition, not a hope. If a second adult genuinely cannot be secured for a given heavy week, the deep block for that week lightens or defers - the lighter version runs, and the deep version waits until the room can be held. That is the floor working, not the guide failing.

- **The referral pathway, in plain terms.** You are a life-coach and mentor, not a licensed clinician. This year surfaces real clinical material - grief around mortality, shame, hard days - more and earlier than any prior year. Your job is not to treat it. It is to recognize when something is past coaching, hold the moment safely, and route it to real help fast. Route now, do not “work it in a session,” if you see or hear any of these: any mention of suicide, self-harm, or not wanting to be here; abuse, neglect, or someone hurting them; a crisis happening right now: panic, a flashback, feeling cut off from their own body, or distress you cannot reach; signs of something going wrong with eating; a crisis with drugs or alcohol; a threat to someone else; something past an ordinary hard day: it keeps going, and it is getting in the learner’s way. When in doubt, route. Being sure is a clinician’s job, not yours. Stay with the learner, never leave them alone in crisis, move to the designated quiet space, be calm and present, do not ask for details or counsel. The referral roster must be built real - real names and current numbers - before Session 1 runs, and the one line that must never stay blank is a named, warm-referral therapist arranged in advance. In Idaho everyone is a mandatory reporter, including you; suspected

abuse or neglect gets reported, ideally within twenty-four hours, and you do not need proof, because the law gives the judging to the state. This duty does not give you a key to the Log: you do not read it, so it cannot be a source; what the duty reaches is what a learner tells you, shows you or hands you, and what you see and hear in the room. Say that distinction out loud on day one. 988 is the crisis line; keep those numbers current and on paper, because in a crisis the phone in your hand is already doing something else, and a number you have to search for is a number you do not call. The pathway runs across breaks, not only on program days, and the learner is told so before each one.

- **Keep confidences safe.** Say the privacy words on day one, woven into the promises you make each other, and say them as written rather than improvising a warmer version, because a learner who hears a different wording than the one they read goes looking for the seam:

> *"Almost everything you write and say here is yours. Your Captain's Log, nobody reads - including me, and I won't go looking. What I can't keep private is a short list, and I'd rather you hear it now than find out later: if you're in danger, if someone's hurting you, or if something's going on that's bigger than I can hold here. That's when I bring in real help, and usually that means a call home too. I'll tell you when I'm doing it. That's not breaking trust - it's what care actually looks like."*

Those are the same promises that are on the learner's privacy page in Part 1, in your own voice. Said up front, that is a promise kept. Said only in the moment, it feels like betrayal.

- **The gate before each heavy session, in writing.** The second adult is a precondition, and a precondition is not a check. Three times this year - before the first heavy Tuesday of No Easy Answers, before the death scene, and before the Council's first deep deliberation day - stop and certify, in writing, dated, on the plan, that the floor built in August is still real today: the quiet space is still a room and not a cupboard; the named clinician still has a current number, will still take the call, and in December is reachable across the holiday or has a named backup who is; the one adult outside the room is reachable across the break that follows; the second adult is named, by name, for the day; and the consented walk of this session's floor has happened, with the date and who walked it. Name the second adult because a rule met by "I'll find someone" is a feeling, and a gate nobody signs is a gate nobody holds. It is three times and not once because the Helm's heavy sessions sit in October, December and April, and a pathway built before Session 1 is eight months old by the Council; numbers go stale, rooms get repurposed, and a second adult in a room with a dead referral number is a held room with no trapdoor. A solo studio has

no second signature, so the guide self-certifies and says so plainly. Coach, not therapist: the gate certifies the container, never a treatment. If a line cannot be signed, the lighter version runs that week, and that is the floor working.

- **Material is chosen, not sprung; opt-in by readiness.** The heaviest content is previewed, alternates are chosen before the day and never improvised, because an alternate chosen on the day is chosen in front of the learner who needs it and announces them. No learner is required to disclose anything about their own life to take part. The lighter version of the whole year is the honorable first pass, because a floor never run has never been tested and the first tribe is the test. The full version is a choice a rested tribe makes on purpose, before the year, never something a tired room slides into, because exhaustion decides late, after the heavy day is on the calendar, while readiness decides early.

Leadership styles taught by example

In the leadership work you will use well-known ship captains and public leaders as examples - different styles of leading, all real. Present them plainly, as public teaching examples. “Here are four real captains with four different styles; which do you lead like?” is a teaching device, nothing more. They are not insider lore and they are not personas giving advice. They are examples a learner can look up on their own, the way you would study any public leader.

Holding a “no” - three beats

Decline-with-reasoning lives or dies in the single moment a learner actually says no. If that moment collapses into invisible opt-out - silence, the activity just continues around them - the learner is protected by being erased from the room. So hold a no in three beats, and you can run them under load:

1. **Receive the no, whole.** “Okay. You’re not doing this one.” Honor it *before* any curiosity, so your curiosity never lands as a lever.
2. **Offer the door once, and don’t push it.** “That no stands, and it’s done. When you’ve worked out what’s behind it, the tribe will want to hear it. Not me - them. And not today.” Hold both halves or you have turned the practice into a toll: the reasoning is genuinely owed to the room, and it is genuinely not owed in the moment. If a learner never comes back to it, that is between them and the tribe, and it is not yours to collect.
3. **Keep them inside the encounter.** “Come sit with me - you don’t have to do the thing.” Removing the task is not the same as removing the person.

Your curious question stays a mirror, never a way to scare someone into yes. Ask “when do you think you’ll first run into this for real?” - not “what happens the first time you need this and no one is beside you?” The first opens a door with curiosity; the second forecasts them alone and unequipped, which lands on an anxious learner as “you’ll be sorry.” And “the right kind of scared” is the learner’s to name about themselves. It is never yours to assign to them. You have a voice. You never have a veto.

Watch-fors, and protect yourself

This year asks the most of the guide, too. Holding hard material costs the holder, and the whole floor depends on you having enough reserve left to notice the one learner going under.

- **Run your own floor.** Do your own settle, your own way down at day’s end, your own closing minute. This is safety instrumentation, not self-care - a guide whose own body is flooded cannot run the watch-and-pivot. The room reads your nervous system faster than any lesson plan can counter.
- **Debrief after every heavy day.** After each heavy deep day, debrief with a peer or supervisor before the next heavy session. Do not carry it alone.
- **A second adult on the heaviest days** protects you as much as the room.
- **Lightening or deferring is honorable.** If the load is too much in a given week, the lighter version is the floor working. What you can hold sets how many learners are in the room, and both come before money, because a learner enrolled on coverage not yet secured is one the floor cannot hold, and the day it fails is the day you find out.
- **Your fallow day is fallow too, and so are the breaks.** Protected, not on-call. The learner’s page says plainly that you are not reachable over a break, so you never have to improvise that limit on the last guided day; what you say aloud before each break is who is: the one adult outside the room, and 988. Every session here ends into a break: the September break after the Mantle, the October break after No Easy Answers, Thanksgiving after the Ripple, the two-week winter break after the Stage and its death scene, the February break after the Arena of Voices while a mentor’s silence may still be landing, the April break after the Bridge, and after the Council, Open Waters, which holds the Launch for a leaving learner, and then the summer, the longest absence in the cycle. Say it on the last guided day, every time, in one fixed form: “The break starts Friday and runs [length]. I won’t be reachable - that’s my rest too. [Name] is, the whole time, not only on studio days; here is how to reach them. 988 is free and open all day and all night, call or text, from anywhere. The path to real help stays open the whole break. I’m back in the room on [day].” For the winter break, say the real date back, not “January.” For the summer, say it on Open Waters’ last guided day, Thu May 23.

Part 3 - The sessions

Each session below gives you: what it's for, a plain word for the learner, the flow, things you might say, the settle and closing minute, watch-fors, and what you'll need. Each session header carries its calendar weeks and projected dates; the week labels inside a session count from that session's first week. The weeks inside a session follow one small grammar, and the word in brackets after each week says which beat it is: a session opens, deepens, applies, and harvests. The week the work leaves the room and comes back is a gather. A three-week session doubles up. The Arena of Voices' fourth week is named what it is: fallow. A week left unplanned carries no beat, because a beat is a job and nobody has given it one.

One word about words. Part 1 said the Log is kept however you hold it, and that holds all year. When the sessions below say write, draft, or read, they mean put it in your Log and go back to it, in whatever form yours takes. The book says write because it is the shortest word, not because it is the only way. The same holds for stand, walk, speak, perform, wear, and cross: they mean take part in the way your body takes part. And anything the room listens to has a transcript in the room; anything the room reads can be heard. Both are on the table for everyone before anyone needs them; nobody has to ask.

Session 1 - The Mantle (four weeks, Aug 13 - Sep 6)

What it's for. To open the year by meeting imposter feeling honestly - naming it as the felt sensation of growth, not a defect - and to take up the Mantle you will carry all year. The imposter's lie is "everyone else belongs here and I snuck in." The truth is that accomplished people feel it too, and for many people it fades with acting, not with proving. For some it stays, and they act with it there.

For the learner. "Who am I to make hard calls?" Most people feel that knot when they reach past what they can already do, including people who have done a great deal. This session names that feeling and puts something beside it: real evidence of hard things you have already done, pulled from your own record. Then there is a rite, the Mantle, where you may say aloud what you are taking up for the year. For some people worthiness arrives after the acting. For some it doesn't, and they act anyway. Both are the year.

Here is the whole of it, said now. You will not be asked to share a time you felt like a fraud. The adults do that part - the guide and a mentor say theirs, specifically - and you receive it. If you want one of yours in the room, you put it on a card with no name and the guide reads it as "someone here once felt." Nobody can see who wrote and who did not. Right after, same morning, you build your Evidence File from any real proof you have: the Origin portfolio if you

were here for it, your Forge project, work from outside the studio. In the fourth week there is a short rite, and you will hear the whole of it on the Tuesday before. You'll be asked to say one sentence, in your own words, about what you're taking up this year. You can say it to the room, say it quietly to your chosen witness only, put it on a card the witness reads out, or say nothing and still take the mantle. The mantle is a real object; you take it up yourself, worn, held, or set in your hands. One person you chose says back what they saw. If you don't take it up this session, nothing in the year closes to you; you can take it up any week in a walk-in, and the Council is open to you either way. Stepping out mid-rite costs nothing.

The flow.

Weeks 1-4 · Aug 13 - Sep 6 · off: Mon Sep 3, Labor Day

The fourth week goes to the front, as Origin's did. After the rite there is already air: a break with the mantle at home, then the craft weeks of No Easy Answers before its heavy block. Before the first heavy thing there was none: the first week carried the exit ramp, the privacy words, the one adult, the destination, the agreements, the Log and Vineyard for a joiner, and then on Thursday an adult stranger saying a time they felt like a fraud, in the week the room met. So the first week is the crossing into the year, and nothing heavy is in it. The room is mixed - returners who know each other and learners for whom this is day one - so everything is carried on a shared task, side by side, so the joiner is never the only person being introduced.

Week 1 (open) is the threshold week. **Tuesday: arrival, then the door.** The walk-in, the settle (fix your words this week and keep them), the circle with pass, the map of the year, the Table. Then the exit ramp is built and walked before any promise is asked for; then the privacy words as written, and the one adult outside the room named with how to reach them, and breaks said. Say the day-one line. Introduce the no-win frame on something game-sized, as the same muscle. Say the word for the knot, imposter feeling, once, as a name only: "Most people hearing that line feel a knot. It has a name, and next week two adults will tell you about theirs." The modelling waits a week. **Wednesday: nothing is asked back. Thursday: the tribe's own half.** The floor said first, the six things the agreements cannot make enforceable; the agreements co-written, on cards or aloud, named reopenable with the when said in words; the no-sign line said. Then, separate, the carried objects: the Log named for anyone new, every form on the table and said to the whole room so no one is the only person being told; the Vineyard re-opened for returners and named in the walk-in for anyone new, never in a round. Name the crew, and say which days the second adult is first in the room, so the heavy days of the next session are already visible from here. Week 2 (deepen): Tuesday is lighter - the no-win question, group work, and the real act seeded, "this week or next, one real thing that scares you a little." Thursday, the deep day: the guide and the invited mentor model imposter feeling, genuinely and specifically, and the learners receive it; the cards, optional, in any form a learner can make alone, read once in the guide's voice with no name, then gone. The same morning, before the way down, the Evidence File is begun, from each learner's own record in the form it was made -

the learner's page promises "right after, same morning," and the flow keeps that promise, because nobody leaves with the knot surfaced and the counterweight unbuilt. Week 3 (apply): "Why not you?" The Evidence File grows across the week; the real act, once done, goes into it in the learner's own words, whether it found worthiness or only a thing done. Walk-ins carry the credit and path conversation for anyone whose last year this is. Thursday: the mantle object is brought into the room and handled, with no ask attached; each learner chooses their witness privately in the walk-in. Week 4 (harvest): **Tuesday, the approach.** The rite told in full, all four movements, the three ways to say the sentence and the fourth way of saying nothing; the object in the room again; a learner who wants to draft their sentence does it in their Log, or does not. Ask the pace question at this day's close, so the crossing day carries nothing else. **Wednesday is the interval, named out loud as one:** learner-run, one carried question, "what are you taking up?", nothing handed in; the sentence is chosen after a night and a day of the learner's own air, not in the hour the object was handed to them. **Thursday, the rite**, on the deep day, so the crossing gets its silence: the threshold, the object, the witness, the wearing. The way down, the Table and the hands block are the landing - the mantle worn into an ordinary hour of the same morning, and nobody asks about it. Close with the close-return and the closing minute at session scale; say who is reachable over the break and that you are not, and that the agreements are open; then the mantle goes home. A learner who did not take it up has a walk-in any week of the year.

This is the rebuilt session - read this carefully. The old version had "everyone shares a time they felt like a fraud, going around the circle." That is gone, on purpose. Shame and imposter feeling are not the same emotion. Imposter feeling ("I don't belong here yet") is generative. Public shame disclosure in a peer group, at the age of peak peer-sensitivity, can wound lastingly - and opting out of a shame ritual in front of peers becomes its own quiet shame event. So the structure is fixed:

- The dissolving power comes from **adults modeling, learners receiving** - not from any learner being required to share.
- No circle-round, no going-around.
- If a learner *wants* to share, it is **non-attributed** - put on a card in any form a learner can make alone (written, typed, or recorded alone in the quiet space) and always read aloud in the guide's voice, with no name ("someone here once felt…"). The guide's voice is what keeps abstention invisible for a learner who cannot write.
- **Abstention is invisible.** In a "receive, then optionally make a card" structure, no one can see who chose not to. That is the only way opt-out is real in a peer room. The cards are read once and then gone; nobody keeps them or matches a hand to a name.
- The Evidence File comes immediately after, the same morning. Never leave a room having surfaced shame without building the counterweight of real evidence of competence.

Things to say. - “In May you make a hard call in the open, before your people. Everything from here is getting ready to sit in that chair and mean it.” - “That feeling of not-belonging-yet? Accomplished people feel it too. It doesn’t mean you snuck in. It means you’re reaching.” - “Why not you? If not you, who?” - “You don’t have to feel ready to act. Many find the feeling comes after. If it doesn’t, you still did the thing, and the thing was real.” - (At the rite) “I saw you take that up.”

The settle and the closing minute. Open with the settle - shame lives in the body (heat, dropped gaze, a curled spine), so settle the room before you touch the material. Go in small steps: the adults speak first and nothing is asked of anyone at the start, so the counterweight of evidence is built before anything heavy is held. Close with the close-return. This is an opening session, so the closing minute matters; “take your closing minute” is the whole prompt, and “I don’t know yet” is a real close.

Watch-fors. A learner who dips into shame needs the room to treat it as normal and needs the exit ramp they can use without asking. What someone puts on a card can be bigger than a card; the referral pathway is live before this session runs. Guard the order so that any modeling is never the price of admission to the Mantle; the evidence of worth must be reachable by the learner who says nothing aloud.

What you’ll need. One shared task to carry the first week; cards for agreement contributions; an invited mentor for the modeling in week 2; cards for optional non-attributed sharing, in any form a learner can make alone; each learner’s own record for the Evidence File, in the form it was made, with a transcript for any recorded part; the physical mantle object, one that can be worn, held, or placed beside a learner, and a witness each learner chooses for the rite; the exit ramp and quiet space set up; the one adult outside the room, written; the referral pathway live.

Session 2 - No Easy Answers (five weeks, Sep 17 - Oct 18) - one of the three heaviest

What it’s for. To learn to reason through real moral dilemmas from principle, out loud, without an answer key. The world does not hand you the right answer. The win is not the verdict - it is the quality of the reasoning and the honesty about the cost. This is how the captain who will hold the Council learns to think.

For the learner. Some questions have no clean right answer, and pretending they do is a lie. This session you practice standing inside one long enough to reason from your own principles instead of grabbing the exit. The cases come through story and real history, so you can think about heavy things at full weight without anyone saying anything about their own life.

Here is what the stories touch, said now so none of it is a surprise: a person who wants to end their own suffering; being forced; being pressed to be like everyone else; and the Dred Scott case, which is not the other side of a hard call but a real court reasoning its way into evil - we study it to learn the difference. The two heaviest weeks are previewed, each has a lighter alternate ready, and a second adult is in the room: not to watch you, but so that if one person needs to leave, someone goes with them and the room still stands. You can step out any time, no reason owed. The harvest is a reasoned position on a hard case. “I can name the two goods that collide here and I haven’t decided” is a reasoned position.

The flow.

Weeks 5-9 · Sep 17 - Oct 18 · off: Mon Oct 8, Indigenous Peoples’ Day / Columbus Day · the two heavy days are Tuesdays, Oct 2 and Oct 9, with the second adult in the room

This session opens after the first break of the year: re-thread first. The method is moral dilemmas told through allegory, meaning a story that stands in for a real thing (well-known dramatic episodes), tied to real historical cases - personhood (paired with the Dred Scott case), due process under fear (paired with McCarthyism), loyalty versus truth (paired with whistleblowing). Weeks 1 and 2 (open, deepen) build the reasoning craft on progressively harder cases, and they build the floor’s habits on light ground at the same time: the Reasoning Standard is in every learner’s hands, the difference between a real dilemma and a rationalized wrong is taught, and the pre-brief (name the terrain, name the exit, name that no reason is owed) is run before the week 1 and week 2 deep blocks, so that by week 3 it is a familiar shape rather than a warning. On the Thursday of week 2, Sep 27, preview both heavy weeks to the room - what each touches and which day - and take the readiness read in the walk-in, one learner at a time, never round the circle, so the alternate for anyone who needs one is chosen then, in advance, and nobody is announced on the day. Weeks 3 and 4 (apply) are the heaviest cases, one each week, previewed and alternated. In these two weeks the heavy thing runs on the Tuesday, so the held day is the Thursday and no one carries it alone into a weekend: the second adult is in the room on Tue Oct 2 and Tue Oct 9, and Thu Oct 4 and Thu Oct 11 open no new heavy ground. Week 4’s Tuesday follows the holiday weekend, so its pre-brief carries the whole arrival and assumes nothing from week 3 is still warm. Ask the pace question at the close of week 3, Thu Oct 4, while there is still time to act on the answer before the second heavy case. If the second adult cannot be there on a heavy Tuesday, the lighter alternate runs that morning and the deep version waits outside this session; it does not move into week 5. Week 5 (harvest) has nothing heavy in it: each learner makes a reasoned position on a hard case, held from principle - not “won” - and an undecided position honestly reasoned is a whole harvest. On the last guided day, Thu Oct 18, ask the pace question, run the closing minute at session scale, and say aloud who is reachable over the break.

The spine of the session is the **Reasoning Standard** - five structural questions the reasoning must answer, none of which is "what is the right answer." Use it to coach, to self-assess, and to hold yourself to as well:

1. **Principles named** - which two or more genuine goods conflict here? (If there is only one real principle, it is not a dilemma - it may be a rationalized wrong. Say which.)
2. **Cost owned** - what does your path cost, and to whom? (A path that claims to be free is hiding its cost.)
3. **Steelman survived** - can you state the position you rejected well enough that its holder would say "yes, that's it"?
4. **Reversibility** - would you accept this reasoning if you were the person it costs?
5. **Framework visible** - are you reasoning through consequences, duty, character, or care? What does a different lens see that yours misses?

Two guardrails to teach. There is a well-known map of how moral reasoning grows up, made by a psychologist named Kohlberg; it describes *arguments*, never ranks *people*, and the map itself is argued over - say so. And teach the distinction between a genuine dilemma and a rationalized wrong. Some paired cases are real dilemmas. Some are not - Dred Scott is the study of how a system reasoned itself into evil, not "the other side of a hard call." A curriculum that cannot tell those apart teaches false equivalence. Teaching learners to tell them apart teaches the sharpest blade of the year. Real cases get real study - primary voices, the human cost named - or the pairing drops to allegory only. Honor the reality, or do not borrow its weight.

Things to say. - "The world doesn't come with an answer key. The win here isn't the answer - it's how well you reasoned and how honestly you named the cost." - "A story that stands in for the real thing isn't the watered-down version. It's the tool that lets us think about the hardest things at full weight, and nothing about your own life has to come into the room." - "Say the strongest version of the side you disagree with - well enough that someone who holds it would say, yes, that's exactly it." - "Dred Scott isn't the other side of a dilemma. It's how a whole system reasoned itself into evil. Learning to tell those apart is the whole game." - (In the heaviest weeks) "Today's story touches death and the choice to end suffering. You can step out any time, you don't owe anyone a reason, and there's water and a chair by the window."

The settle and the closing minute. Every heavy day: the settle to open, a short way down between hard passages (thirty seconds: feet on the floor or hands on the chair, look around the room, one breath), the close-return in its fixed words. Pre-brief before every flagged-heavy episode - name the terrain, name the exit, name that no reason is owed. This is arrival, not ambush, and it does the most for the least of anything you do. The dilemma work is an opening; close it with the closing minute (the feeling-side twin of the Reasoning Standard - reason the hard call, *and* re-cross what it stirred).

Watch-fors. Second adult required on the two heavy Tuesdays. Preview-and-alternate the heaviest episodes - assisted death, coercion, identity and conformity - with alternates chosen before the day, never improvised. The dilemma can be unflinching about the world; the learner's own interior is never required as material. If the care starts to sound like a prediction, as if the room expects you to fall apart, say less about the net and keep every bit of it in place.

What you'll need. The allegory episodes and their alternates pre-selected, each captioned, with a transcript, and audio-described where a described version exists - where none does, the guide says aloud what is on the screen as it plays; the paired real cases with primary sources, in print and audio; the Reasoning Standard on one page and read aloud once; a second adult secured for the two heavy Tuesdays, named before the session opens; the settle, the way down, the close-return and the exit ramp in place; the referral pathway live.

Session 3 - The Ripple (three weeks, Oct 29 - Nov 15, ends into Thanksgiving)

What it's for. To learn consequence-thinking - looking one, two, three moves downstream of a choice, and being honest that you cannot see all the way. Good captains think in ripples, not single points. This is a deliberately lighter, playful beat between the two heaviest sessions.

For the learner. A hard call doesn't end when you make it. It sets things in motion - some you meant, some you didn't. This session is about looking downstream before you act, and staying humble about the part of the river you can't see yet.

The flow.

Weeks 10-12 · Oct 29 - Nov 15 · on a guide day: Tue Nov 6, Election Day, observance decided before the session · off: Mon Nov 12, Veterans Day observed · ends into Thanksgiving

Re-thread first, short. The tools are games and maps: the Ripple Board (map the first-, second-, and third-order effects of a choice), the Monkey's Paw (every wish granted with an unforeseen cost - the shadow side of "solutions"), counterfactual history (change one thing, follow the ripples), and the Pre-Mortem (imagine the choice already failed - why?). Week 1 (open, re-thread) opens with the games, week 2 (deepen) goes downstream two and three moves, week 3 (apply, harvest) harvests a real decision traced forward, with blind spots owned and agency kept.

This session opens after the break: re-thread first. Because it is medium-weight and safe, it is one of the two homes for meeting a hard thing with only the ordinary supports rather than the full net - the guide present, the exit available, but the visible net turned down. This is chosen and named by the learner, never sprung, for a learner who chooses it, launching this year or not,

and never pressed on a learner already carrying more than enough. Reduce the visible net, never the floor's availability. The last guided day of this session is the last before Thanksgiving: ask the pace question, run the closing minute at session scale, and say aloud who is reachable over the break, and that you are not.

Things to say. - "Every choice sends ripples. Chase the cascade - then what? And then what?" - "The wish always comes with a twist. What's the shadow of this solution?" - "You can't see all the way downstream, and pretending you can is its own mistake. The move is: act wisely, watch for the ripples, adjust."

The settle and the closing minute. Carry the settle and the close even though the day is light - a light session still bookends. Closing minute as usual.

Watch-fors. Consequence-thinking can tip into anxiety ("what if everything goes wrong"). Always pair it with agency - "and here is the move you can still make." The point is wiser action, not fear of acting. Keep this session light on purpose; do not import heavy material into the room's breath between the two hardest sessions. No second adult needed.

What you'll need. The Ripple Board setup, said aloud as each ripple goes up; a Monkey's Paw story or two, read aloud or with a transcript; counterfactual prompts; each learner's own Forge project for the Pre-Mortem, or any real decision of their own for a learner who joined this year.

Session 4 - The Stage (three weeks, Nov 26 - Dec 13, ends into the winter break) - one of the three heaviest

What it's for. To feel a hard call from inside the lives it touches, through theatre - and to practice the discipline of stepping fully into another life and cleanly back out again. The distance of the stage is a safety feature, like allegory: you can *be* the person who makes the other choice.

For the learner. To make a hard call well, you have to feel it from inside the lives it touches. Theatre is a way to practice that from a safe distance: you try a person on, then you step out of them, and stepping out whole matters as much as stepping in. Performing is always a choice; watching is equal, and the harvest is yours in either shape: a moment you performed, or a moment you witnessed and can say what the other person carried.

One play, *Our Town*, has a scene where a young woman who has died comes back to relive one ordinary day. That is the one place this year where the story does not stand between you and the thing, because death on a stage is death. So, said now: that day is the second Tuesday of this session, the one Tuesday this year that carries the deep block, so the Thursday after it can be a held day with nothing new in it; a second adult is in the room that morning; there is a named exit for that scene; and if you have lost someone recently and would want the day planned

around you, tell the guide once, one to one, any time before that week. The guide will ask you too, in the first week, never in the circle, and you can say you would rather not answer. You decide what to say and whether to; nobody goes looking. Every role is chosen. You can perform, hand a role to the tribe, watch, or decline.

The flow.

Weeks 13-15 · Nov 26 - Dec 13 · ends into the winter break · the death scene is Tue Dec 4, with the second adult in the room, and Thu Dec 6 is held

Week 1 (open, re-thread) opens after Thanksgiving: re-thread first, then warm-ups and improv as play, and the first de-roling on a role that is nothing, a shopkeeper or a weather report, so the move (say or sign your name, three true things about your real life, prop down, shake out, feel what is under you) is in the body on something that costs nothing before it is needed on something that does; every learner de-roles at least twice from a light role before Dec 4. Tell the room on this Tuesday what the three weeks hold: that the death scene is next Tuesday, the one Tuesday this year that carries the deep block, and that the Thursday after it is held; describe the scene in words and offer the four ways to be in the room for it (perform, hand the role to the tribe, witness, decline), now, because offering them on the day they land is too late for the learner who needs them. On the own day between, each learner finds or writes a monologue from someone facing a hard call; on the Thursday the monologues are given from the inside, in voice, sign, or a recording, performing voluntary, witnessing equal, de-roled every single time. Across this week's one-to-ones, the noon check-ins and the walk-ins and never the circle, the guide asks each learner whether there is a recent loss they would want next Tuesday planned around; it is the week after Thanksgiving, so for some the loss is five days old again. A learner may tell the guide before being asked and may decline to answer, nothing is written either way, and the plan for that day, alternate included, is set by Thursday, Nov 29. Week 2 (deepen) is *Our Town* and its question: "Do any human beings ever realize life while they live it?" Emily returns from death to relive one ordinary day. It runs on the Tuesday, Dec 4, with the second adult in the room, the exit named for the scene, the pre-brief said, every role chosen, the Table as the come-down, the close-return in its fixed words. The Thursday, Dec 6, is the held day: no new hard ground, the room together, improv and play if the room wants them, the play's ordinary morning read seated if the room wants the play back in daylight, hands and each other, the closing minute, and the pace question, with a week left to act on it; nobody carries Emily alone into a weekend. Week 3 (apply, harvest) is the lighter week, designed and not accidental, and nothing in it touches death or recent loss: the Tuesday is theatre as play again, and each learner chooses the moment they will bring to the harvest, one performed or one witnessed. This is the first half of the midpoint crossing, because the midpoint of the year is the winter break itself, crossed with the learner's body out of the room: on the Tuesday ask the re-ask (*is this still yours?*) to the room and take the answers one at a time across the week's one-to-ones, never round the circle. The Thursday, Dec 13, harvests a moment of empathy, stepping fully into another life and back out whole, performed or witnessed, and "I watched, and here is what she

was carrying" is a whole harvest. Then the look-back across the four sessions so far (the Mantle taken up, the reasoning, the ripple, the lives tried on - who are you becoming?), the pace question, and the re-entry note to your future self so the throughline survives two weeks away. It is the last guided day before the two-week winter break: say aloud who is reachable across it, that 988 is always open, that you are not until the real date back, and that the pathway stays live the whole time, the clinician's holiday availability having been confirmed in writing before Dec 4; say the agreements are open; run the closing minute at session scale. In the lighter Stage, week 2's Tuesday runs the play's ordinary morning and asks Emily's question of the living, with no death scene and no second adult needed, and everything else is the same. Forum Theatre, which this session once held, now lives in the Bridge, where stopping a scene and stepping in is practiced as holding the room, and it pays off in the Council from there.

Archetypes are taught as **doorways, not identities**: you try a way of being on; you are not it. "I encountered the Hero," never "I am the Hero."

Two closes are kept strictly separate here. **De-roling** closes a *role* - "that wasn't me." The **closing minute** closes a real *feeling* the role opened - "that was me, and I carry it, and I'm still here." Never de-role real grief. De-roling teaches "that wasn't me"; grief needs "that was me, and I am still here." Keep the line bright.

Things to say. - "You're not becoming this person. You're trying them on. It's a doorway, not who you are." - "Do any of us ever really realize life while we're living it? Every, every minute?" - (After an embodiment, the de-roling) "Say or sign your own name. Name three things true about your real life right now - I am [name], I am 17, it's Tuesday, I have soccer after this. Now shake out your hands, or whatever part of you moves, and feel what's under you - the floor, the chair, your own hands." - (For real grief that surfaces) "That was real. That was you. Let's not push it out - it can stay, and you're still here." - (The Tuesday before, and again that morning) "Next Tuesday is the one Tuesday this year that's the deep day. The story touches death, and it doesn't stand between you and it the way the others have. You can step out any time, no reason owed; [name] is in the room so nobody goes out alone; and Thursday is held, nothing new." - (At the harvest) "If you watched, tell us what she was carrying. That's a whole harvest."

The settle and the closing minute. The settle to open, a short way down in the middle of the work, the close-return at the end, every heavy day. De-role after *every* embodiment, with the real mechanic (say or sign your name, three true things about your real life, remove the prop, shake out, feel what is under you) - not once per session, every single time a body wears another life, because the nervous system does not know a role is pretend; it runs the state for real. The first de-roling in week 1 is on a role that costs nothing, so the move is a reflex before it is needed. Then the closing minute for anything real the role opened.

Watch-fors. Second adult required on the *Our Town* death-scene deep day - it is the one place this year's story-distance does not apply, because death on the stage *is* the real thing, and it lands straight on anyone carrying a recent loss, with no story in between. Ask in the first week, across the noon check-ins and the walk-ins so every learner is reached one to one and never in the circle, whether anyone has lost someone recently and would want the scene planned around them; it is the week after Thanksgiving, so for some the loss is five days old again. The learner decides what to tell you; you do not go looking, and nothing is written either way. The ask is finished and the alternate chosen by the first Thursday; this is a judgment made before the day, never improvised, with a previewed exit named for that scene specifically. The death-scene Tuesday carries the Thursday shape, the deep block and the second adult; if the second adult falls through, the scene does not run Dec 4 and does not move to Dec 11, the lighter Stage runs, and there is no later home in the year for the scene, so that is the year's answer. The held Thursday and the lighter week exist so that nobody's last sight of the room before two weeks away is Emily. Roles are always chosen; a role can be given to the tribe only, witnessed rather than performed, or declined. Protect the theatre-as-play as genuine joy, not only a safety warm-up, and keep the Vineyard distinct from the de-roling toolkit, because the moment the thing you love is used to bring you down from a role it has been made useful, and that is the day it dies.

What you'll need. Monologue sources in print, large print, and audio; the *Our Town* text in a form each learner can read or hear, any film of it captioned with a transcript, and the death scene described in words before it runs; the second adult confirmed for the second Tuesday before the session opens, and the lighter Stage ready if that falls through; the referral roster's holiday availability confirmed in writing before Dec 4, with a named backup who is reachable Dec 20 to Jan 2; whatever learners chose to tell you about a recent loss; a previewed exit; the de-roling space and mechanic; the settle, the way down, the close-return and the exit ramp; the referral pathway live.

Session 5 - The Arena of Voices (six weeks, Dec 31 - Feb 7)

What it's for. To learn from real adults walking the road ahead - professional mentors and guest speakers - and to learn the real skill of being mentored well. No one navigates alone. Being mentored can be a threshold. Some feel seen by it; some get a useful answer and nothing more; both count.

For the learner. Some adults are further down your road, and a conversation with one can be worth a lot. This session you learn how to be mentored: come with one real question you actually want answered, ask it, and say thank you afterward. Two honest things before you write to anyone. A lot of people won't answer. That says nothing about you; busy people are busy, and silence says nothing about your worth. And one-to-one mentors may not happen this year, because the structure that keeps that door safe is still being built. If it is not ready, nobody is

passed over: the guest speakers and your own interview are the whole session, not a lesser one. You will hear which it is in the second week, before anyone writes to anyone. Any mentoring match can be ended with one word to the guide, no reason owed. “I reached out and nothing came back” is a real harvest.

The flow.

Weeks 16-21 · Dec 31 - Feb 7 · on a guide day: Tue Jan 1, New Year’s Day (as projected; the real break likely moves) · off: Mon Jan 21, MLK Day · no break inside this session

Being mentored is a threshold: the ask is the crossing, the wait is the held threshold, the reply is the landing, the thank-you is the carrying forward. Three of those four movements cannot be put on a schedule without lying about them. Only the thank-you can, and it is the learner’s own act, which needs no reply. That is what keeps six weeks from becoming a march. Week 1 (open, re-thread) is the second half of the midpoint crossing: the big re-thread as the whole first morning and nothing else, where were you, where are you now, what came back changed, after the longest gap of the year, which followed the death scene; the safety floor said aloud again, the exit ramp, the one adult, the pathway; no prompt. As printed this week has one guide day; one is enough for this. If the real calendar gives the week its Tuesday back, Tuesday is the re-thread and Thursday a light Work of the Day with nothing asked; nothing else in the flow moves. Week 2 (deepen) is the art of being mentored: prepare, ask, follow up; questions drafted; the no-answer line said before anyone writes to anyone; the two-track told plainly - whether the one-to-one door is open this year was decided before the session, and this is the week the learner hears which, never later; “I’m not asking anyone” named now as a true answer to the session’s question. Week 3 (apply) is the ask: the first guest speaker, the window - the drafted questions asked of a live adult, answered in the room, the thank-you said before they leave - so the whole rite is walked once, small and held, before anyone walks it at a distance where the reply may never come. At the end of the week the asks go out, from whoever chooses to send one. Week 4 (gather) is the fallow week, and it stays empty. No new voices. **This is the year’s one deliberately empty stretch inside the arc, and it is un-harvested: no Work of the Day, nothing reported, nothing to hand in.** The grid still runs, and the middle block is low-stakes craft, or nothing. The question went out last week and is answered when it is answered. The guide’s work this week is the walk-in, for whoever wants to say where the ask stands: sent, answered, still waiting, or not sent. “Not sent” closes the question, and nobody is asked it twice. Nobody is behind. The silence is the session’s work, not a gap before it; the pace question sits in this week’s walk-ins, one to one. MLK Day removes the Monday. Week 5 is held, not filled: nothing is planned for it, on purpose. Replies that have come are received on their own clock - an interview happens when it happens, on an own-day, in the hands block, or after the session has ended - and a second guest speaker has a home here at the Table if one is sourced warmly, but the week stands whole without one and the book does not plan for one. Week 6 (harvest) thanks: a real conversation and what it opened, or “I asked, and nothing has come yet”; the thank-you to everyone asked, replied or not; the pace question; the re-ask (*is this*

still yours?), answered one at a time in the walk-in, never round the circle - after the long middle stretch is the yes that matters, with ten weeks left to act on a no; the closing minute at session scale; who is reachable over the break, and that a reply arriving in February is still received. The mentor door, if the container exists, runs alongside weeks 2 and 3 and the relationship runs past the session on its own clock, into the Bridge; if it does not, nobody is passed over and no week is empty for its absence.

The two-track design (binding). A guest speaker is a window; a one-to-one mentor is a door. Secure them differently.

- **Guest speakers (the window): buildable now, with a modest policy.** Guide present for the entire visit (this alone satisfies the never-alone rule); a public, observable setting; a short expectations sheet the speaker acknowledges (topic scope, no private contact with learners, no photos without consent); parent notification of who and when. No background check is required for a one-time supervised group speaker - the supervision *is* the control, and requiring checks would kill the ability to bring interesting people in. Watch the conversion point: a speaker who starts contacting a learner afterward has walked through the door without being vetted for it - route any follow-up through the guide, which moves them to the mentor track.
- **One-to-one professional mentors (the door): not cleared until the container exists.** Observable channel only - no private messages, personal social media, or off-platform contact; the guide sees that contact exists and how often, never reads the content for assessment. Never-alone satisfied by structure - default remote and monitored; in person only with the guide present or in a public setting, never a private residence or vehicle. A background check before first contact. Three-party informed consent (parent, learner, mentor) plus signed boundaries. A no-fault off-ramp - a learner ends or reports a match with one word to the guide, no reason owed, no confrontation. A written safeguarding and mandatory-reporting policy authored once, on paper, before the first match. And a counsel review of Idaho duty-of-care, mandatory reporting, and liability. Build the container before the first match.
- **Reciprocity - honor the givers, never mine them.** Pay real honoraria and cover costs (a waived fee is accepted only if freely offered, never solicited). Offer a menu of depths - one informational interview, a short arc, or a sustained mentorship - with the one-off honored identically to the year-long. Bounded terms and a dignified exit. The teen arrives prepared. Close the loop: thank them, tell them what their gift did, ask whether it served them too. A professional's hard-call story is a gift, never the price of admission - especially one that sits close to a wound, which is invited freely and never required as content. The mentor is not the load-bearing safeguarding adult; route weight it wasn't built for to the guide.

Source mentors warmly, through communities that already hold relationship - the parent network, local professional and civic bodies - never by cold approach, because a mentor reached through someone who already knows them has a relationship to answer to; a cold one has only the teenager, and a teenager is not a safeguard.

Things to say. - “A good question is a gift to the person answering it. Come with one you actually want answered.” - (The no-answer line, said before any outreach) “If you reach out and hear nothing back - that is not a verdict on you. Busy people are busy. The non-response says nothing about your worth.” - “Tell them what their answer did for you. Close the loop.”

The settle and the closing minute. Carry the settle and the close. Closing minute for what a real conversation opened - or did not.

Watch-fors. The no-answer line matters: reaching out to an admired professional and being ignored is a real wound at this age. Teach “the non-response is not a verdict” *before* the outreach, not as consolation after. This is also the second of the two homes where a learner may choose to meet an ordinary-stakes hard thing with ordinary support - never a manufactured wound, chosen and named by the learner, and never pressed on a learner already carrying more than enough, because the point is an ordinary-sized hard thing met with ordinary support, not a wound made on purpose. Keep the mentor boundary bright.

What you’ll need. The guest-speaker expectations sheet and parent notifications; a second guest speaker only if one is found, since the session stands without one; the mentor-track container fully built before any one-to-one match; a reciprocity plan and honoraria budget; thank-you materials; notes or a transcript of the guest visit for any learner who needs one; the settle in place.

Session 6 - The Bridge (six weeks, Feb 18 - Mar 28)

What it’s for. To practice leading peers and being led well. Leadership is stewardship, not command - the measure of a leader is what continues after they step back. This is where the Mantle is worn in the chair.

For the learner. The best captains lead toward not being needed: they build a crew that can go on without them. This session you may practice both seats, leading and being led, and both are the lesson. You’ll also practice holding a real disagreement from the chair without deciding it, and you will learn the Council’s form here, on a small real question the tribe owns, so that in April the form is already yours and only the dilemma is new. You will be disagreed with, and you will disappoint someone, in a small real thing, on purpose; that is the practice, not something going wrong. Every turn in the chair is a choice, and a turn that went badly is one of the most useful things that can happen here.

The flow.

Weeks 22-27 · Feb 18 - Mar 28 · off: Mon Feb 18, Presidents Day (the session's first day) · no second adult needed

Re-thread first. Week 1 (open, re-thread) opens what leadership is, command against stewardship, "lead toward your own unnecessity," and both chairs are introduced on the first two mornings: the command chair on the Tuesday, with a real group task and the first turn in it, and the convener's chair on the Thursday, with the first low-stakes real disagreement the tribe owns, which from this week is the outing: where, how, who does what. The convener holds the question and refuses to decide it; the tribe decides. Week 2 (deepen) deepens: find-your-style with the public captains on the Tuesday, turns in both chairs continuing, and the hard parts arriving in the debriefs rather than as a lesson - the loneliness of the final call, disappointing someone, being disagreed with, the quiet leader honored. Forum Theatre arrives here from the Stage on the Thursday, as the way the hard parts are met: a hard-call scene acted out, stopped by anyone with the agreed word, gesture or raised card, stepped into, and tried a different way; played seated, voiced or signed as each learner chooses; de-roled after every scene, every time, because the nervous system does not know a role is pretend. Week 3 (deepen) is the Council's form at low stakes. Tuesday: the four seats, the six phases, the Steelman (with Forum Theatre's stop-and-step-in as its tool), the Third Chair, the board read back, the opening and the release, ground-before-you-speak as craft, and the pass signal agreed as a word and a gesture and kept unchanged to May, each with its because. Thursday: run it whole, once, on a real question the tribe owns and nobody's life (what the tribe does with its own Open Waters weeks is one), every seat filled, the voices absorbing the extra learners, a stand-in named for every seat, the dissent read in with the dissenter's yes while dissent still costs nothing. Debrief warmly: "here's the moment you reached for the answer when your job was to hold the question." **Week 4 is part of the session and is not planned; nothing is set for it and nothing is owed in it.** The one thing that may enter it is a turn in either chair the session already owes a learner whose turn has not come; new content may not. The pace question sits at this week's close, Thu Mar 14. Week 5 (apply) is the real outing, late March, planned by the tribe through the convener's chair and led from the command chair, with the guide led, and planned so every learner can go. The debrief after is where a turn that went badly becomes the most useful thing that happened. Week 6 (harvest) harvests a real act of leading and of being led, or an honest account of a turn that went badly, and one question held from the chair without deciding it. On the last guided day, Thu Mar 28, name the Council's real dilemma to the tribe, with the person who will use its Sense of the Room, so it has the break to sit in, and read the Council's form aloud once, the whole of it, saying plainly that the chair you have been practising from the side is the convener's chair. Ask the pace question, say who is reachable over the break and that you are not, and run the closing minute at session scale. One guard: the question the tribe holds in week 3's form practice is about a thing the tribe does, never about a person in it; an interpersonal matter goes to the agreements' ladder, not to a board.

Two kinds of leading are built here, and the second is the one the Council needs. **Rotating command** teaches you to sit in the chair and decide. **Rotating facilitation** teaches you to hold the room from beside it - to hold a question without answering it, so the group can. Each learner takes the convener's chair for a low-stakes *real* cohort disagreement and practices refusing to decide. Debrief warmly ("here's the moment you reached for the answer when your job was to hold the question").

Use well-known captains as public teaching examples of different styles - "which do you lead like?" Present them as public figures anyone can study, never as insider lore.

Things to say. - "Leadership is stewardship, not command. The measure of a leader is what keeps going when they step back." - "Lead toward your own unnecessity. A crew that no longer needs you is the goal, not a loss." - "Leading quietly from the back is a different kind of leadership, not a weaker one." - (The loneliness of command) "When the hard call comes, you make it alone. The crew can advise; the crew can't decide. And here's the thing no one warns you about, and its answer: the captain with a life to go home to - the vineyard, the crew you love - makes better hard calls than the one who only has the chair."

The settle and the closing minute. Carry the settle and the close. The closing minute at every close.

Watch-fors. Guard against the room rewarding the loudest; name and honor the quiet leaders. Being led is a skill too - a learner who only ever leads has not finished the lesson, so rotate genuinely. Hold the hard parts internally, not for optics. In a mixed-age room, do not let the graduating learners' turns become the standard the younger ones measure themselves against - every turn in the chair is honored equally. Collaborative and safe by design; no second adult needed.

What you'll need. Real group tasks and a real outing to lead, planned so every learner can go; real low-stakes disagreements for the convener's chair, the outing's own decisions first; Forum Theatre's scenes, chosen to touch no death or recent loss, with the agreed stop and the de-roling space; the Council's four seats and six phases on one page; the pass signal agreed as a word and a gesture; one real question the tribe owns and nobody's life, for the whole run; the Council's real dilemma and the person who will use its Sense of the Room, ready to name on the last guided day; the second adult's four Council dates secured before this session closes, because a four-week session has no week to wait in; the settle in place.

Session 7 - The Council (four weeks, Apr 8 - May 2) - the harvest, one of the three heaviest

What it's for. To make a hard call in the open, before your people - reasoning from principle, naming the cost, honoring dissent, and either finding the third option or, when there isn't one, choosing anyway with your eyes open. This is the mountain the whole year climbed toward, named on day one. The learner wears the Mantle to hold the room.

For the learner. A council is not a debate to win. It is people of good faith reasoning together toward the best hard call they can make. They name the cost. They keep the dissent in the record. When the choice is a false either-or, they refuse it and look for the third way. When the either-or is real, they choose from principle and carry the cost. What you show is your reasoning, not a verdict on you.

Here is the whole of it, said now. The Council is public, your people in the room, and a second adult is there for the same reason as before. Four roles, chosen and rotating, all equally the Council: the one who holds the question, the voices, the scribe, and the one who speaks for whoever is affected and not present. The dilemma is never anyone's own life. A pass word or gesture hands the floor back at zero cost, mid-sentence, no explanation, and every role has a stand-in named in March and confirmed at the tribe's sitting, so stepping out of a public council costs nothing. The Council sits twice: once with the tribe alone, where every seat is yours, and once with your people in the room. Before the second, you choose in the walk-in whether to hold your seat, hold the scribe's seat instead, or hand your seat to your stand-in and sit with the tribe. All three are the Council, and nobody asks why. The Council opens with a sentence that says this isn't ordinary talk and closes with one that says we didn't solve it and it's closed; you'll hear both in rehearsal. When the room's strongest disagreement is read aloud and left standing, it is in the dissenter's own words and only with their yes. The audience has been told they are witnesses, not judges.

After the Council there is a feast, and the feast is the come-down, not one more thing to get right. The base is provided, nobody watches a plate, and you do not have to eat. There is a named place to step out to that night. If your own family is not in the room, the tribe is your people, and you will not fall through this. The Council is in the last week, in the evening. The morning after it has had its night is the year's close. If you are leaving, the Launch comes after that, in the third week of Open Waters, on a day set with you.

The flow.

Weeks 28-31 · Apr 8 - May 2 · the session break falls before this session (Apr 1-4), not inside it · a second adult on all three Thursdays and at the public sitting

Re-thread first, and then the form, met on something light. The Council's form was learned in the Bridge, on a small real question, and it comes back whole on the first morning, said again rather than taught again: the four seats, the six phases, the Steelman, the Third Chair, the board, the pass signal in the same word and gesture the tribe agreed in March, the opening and the release. Week 1 (open, re-thread) opens the real dilemma, named to the tribe on the Bridge's last guided day. On the Tuesday, with the form back in the room, walk the Third Chair's four questions once on each of two short practice cases from the year's own work, one with a third door and one without, so both shapes are fresh; the daily no-win question has been doing this all year. On the Thursday, the first two phases of the real dilemma: the Frame, then Divergence, every position and the fear under it on the board before anyone argues, read back aloud, with the steward of the absent's first list. Nobody argues this week. Week 2 (deepen) deepens into the middle phases, every seat rotated from week 1. Tuesday is the Steelman, voiced and physical: each voice states the case it rejects until its holder says "yes, that's it," and Forum Theatre's stop-and-step-in is the tool. Thursday is the Cost Ledger, every path's cost and who pays, the absent included, on the board and read back. Ask the pace question at the close of week 2, with two weeks still to act on it. Week 3 (apply) applies. Tuesday is the Turn and the Sense of the Room: the Third Chair's four questions on the real dilemma, whether the "or" is real or inherited, where the reasoning arrived and where it honestly did not. The strongest standing dissent is named, and its holder is asked in the walk-in, never in the circle, whether it may be read into the record in their own words. In that same walk-in each learner says which seat they hold for the public sitting: their own, the scribe's, or their stand-in's, sitting with the tribe. Thursday is the tribe's sitting: the whole Council, opening to release, the tribe alone, every seat held by its holder, each stand-in standing in for one phase so that no stand-in is only a name on a list, the pass signal used at least once on purpose so the room has seen it cost nothing, the dissent read in. This is a Council, not a rehearsal for one; it is also the only dry run the public sitting gets, and if the public sitting cannot be held, the Council has still been held. Week 4 (harvest) harvests. Tuesday morning sets the room: the chairs, the Third Chair, the board carried in as the record, the exit named for that room, the audience's briefing (witnesses, not judges), the feast's base. The public sitting is that Tuesday evening or the Wednesday, families and the tribe, never the Thursday; the Wednesday keeps the day-one line true, since Tuesday is April 30. Then the feast, which is the come-down; the Council, the feast and the year-close never share a day, because the release needs a night before anyone is asked what is different in them. The own-day between is the interval, named as one, nothing asked back. The year-close gets the last guided day, Thursday May 2, to itself, after the feast has had its night (Part 4), with the last re-ask asked there. Then Open Waters, and for a leaving learner, the Launch inside it.

The Council is built as a real form, or teenagers in front of an audience default to what school rehearsed - debate to win:

- **Named, rotating roles:** a *convener* (holds the question, not a position), *voices* (argue the live positions in good faith), a *scribe* (writes the reasoning where the room can see it), and a *steward of the absent* (whose only job is "who is affected by this who is not in the room?").
- **A six-phase sequence:** Frame, then Divergence (surface every position and the fear under it, before anyone argues), then the mandatory Steelman, then the Cost Ledger (every path's cost and who pays, on the board), then the Turn (is the either-or real or inherited? - the Third Chair), then the Sense of the Room (where the reasoning arrived, and where it honestly did not).
- **The Steelman, mandatory and physical:** you may not argue your own position until you have voiced the best version of the one you reject, well enough that its holder says "yes, that's it." This builds honoring dissent into the bones. Forum Theatre from Session 6 pays off here.
- **The Third Chair:** an empty chair placed between hardened sides, with four questions - what is each side protecting? Is the "or" real or inherited? What would honor both values at once? And, when there is no third option, choose from principle and carry the grief honestly.
- **A scribe and a board:** reasoning written where all can see, and read back aloud at the end of each phase so the board is heard as well as seen, becomes the object in the room, not the performers. The strongest unresolved dissent is read into the record in the dissenter's own words, with their yes, and left standing, unrefuted, as part of the harvest. A good decision carries its dissent forward visibly.
- **Mark the opening, and release:** a marked opening ("this is not ordinary talk") and a closing that completes the council without resolving the dilemma ("we did not solve it; we reasoned honestly, together, in front of our people; the council is closed"). That release lets a young person carry an unresolved hard thing without it becoming an open wound.

Let the Council deliberate something with real consequence to the community - a real policy, a real trade-off - so the reasoning matters because it is used, not graded.

Things to say. - "A council isn't a debate. A debate has a winner. A council has discernment." - "You can't argue your side until you've said the other side's best case so well its holder would say, yes, that's it." - "Sometimes there's a third door. Sometimes there isn't. Half the wisdom is finding it; the other half is knowing when there isn't one and choosing anyway, with your eyes open." - (The pass signal) "If you need the floor back, just [the agreed word or gesture]. No cost, no explanation." - (The release) "We did not solve it. We reasoned honestly, together, in front of our people. The council is closed." - (At the tribe's sitting) "This is a Council. Nobody is watching but us, and that makes it no smaller."

The settle and the closing minute. The settle to open, a short way down in the middle of the work, the close-return at the end; pre-brief before each sitting. Build a Council so a body cannot fail it: a pass signal, a word and a gesture both, that returns the floor at zero cost, because freezing is something a body does on its own, not a decision, so make it safe; ground-before-you-speak taught as the captain's own craft (feet on the floor or hands on the chair, one breath; steadying yourself is a skill, not a fix for something wrong with you); the audience briefed as witness, not judge, because a room of warm faces steadies every body in it; and the feast protected as the come-down, not one more thing to get right, because eating together in company is the body's signal that the danger is over.

What the Council leaves unresolved stays unresolved on purpose. Carrying a hard thing that has no answer yet is not waiting for the answer; it is the skill this year was for, and the feast is not where the answer arrives. The public Council is an opening in front of other people and needs its private re-crossing afterward, on the year-close day: the closing minute at the whole year's scale, in its fixed words (Part 4). The capacity to close your own openings, for life, is the deepest thing this year hands a graduate.

Watch-fors. Second adult required on all three Thursdays (Divergence, the Cost Ledger, the tribe's sitting) and at the public sitting, all four secured before the Bridge closes - public moral deliberation is being seen twice over: thinking in public, and being wrong in public. The dilemma is always external, never a learner's own life, because a public Council on your own life is a trial, and the promises say no one's life goes on a board for a room to reason about. No forced self-disclosure. A learner may pass, pause, or come back at zero cost. Name and hold the learner with no family in the room: the tribe is your people, and a chosen witness is honored equally, never as consolation.

What you'll need. One real community dilemma with actual stakes, a real dilemma and not a rationalized wrong, with the person or body who will use its Sense of the Room named to the tribe on the Bridge's last guided day; whether it has a third door is for the Turn to find, not the guide to pre-sort; two short practice cases from the year's own work for week 1's Tuesday; the roles and the six-phase form, with a stand-in for every role named in March and confirmed at the tribe's sitting; a scribe's board, read back at each phase; the Third Chair; a second adult for the three Thursdays and the public sitting, secured before the Bridge closes, and childcare for the public sitting's evening, since Tots is a morning; the pass signal, a word and a gesture both, and the exit ramp confirmed and named for the Council room; the audience told they are witnesses, not judges; the feast planned as the come-down with the full inclusion floor (base provided, presence not consumption, allergen-safe, no cover charge); the referral pathway live.

Part 4 - Closing the year and the Launch

The Council harvest

The public Council is the year's harvest and the arc's. It is the showing of reasoning, never a verdict. Close it with the release that completes it without resolving the dilemma, and protect the feast as the come-down.

The year-close

On the last guided day, after the feast has had its own night, three acts, for every learner, staying or leaving. First, a co-authoring close: the learner reviews the year's design *with* the guide, the design named not hidden - "here is how The Helm was built, and why; tell me what to change." The learner's call on their own year, never a feedback form, and declinable like every other quest. Alongside it, put the whole short record of them on the table, unasked: attendance, pace, credit plan, any safety note. Second, the Captain's Log ownership handoff, said aloud once: the Log is theirs; it goes where they say - home, or back to the one place here only they open for next year - and no copy is kept. That is the same whatever form the Log took: if any of it lives on a studio device or in a scribe's hand, it goes to the learner and nothing stays behind. For a leaving learner, this is also the day the Log goes out the door for good. Alongside the first two, the last re-ask, answered one at a time. Third, the closing minute at the whole year's scale, in its fixed words. It is a naming, not a new ceremony; the practice they have run all year, put in their own hand at the year's scale, and the private re-crossing the public Council needs:

> *"Before what comes next, take your closing minute at the whole year's scale. What did you meet this year? What do you carry back? What's different in you now - even a little? 'I don't know yet' is a real answer."*

For a learner staying on, this is their close between years, and then a real fallow stretch before the next year opens; the fallow day stays empty, and nothing is seated on it. For a leaving learner, it comes three weeks before the Launch, which sits in the third week of Open Waters, so that they cross the threshold already home in themselves.

The tail of the year: Open Waters

The flex tail runs May 6 to May 23, the three weeks after the Council closes on May 2. It is light structure, not a void, and it is not the Council's afterglow or its appeal; what the Council left unresolved stays unresolved here too. Four things live in it, and a fifth for some. Credit close-out, for anyone finishing the year's plan or the whole three years. Project finishing, for what the Bridge built. The relay handed on: the mentor is thanked, and that relationship either goes on, on its own terms and outside this building, or ends well, with the ending named rather than let lapse; and what you built with real people goes to whoever carries it next, or to nobody. And rest, which is a legitimate use of all three weeks; a year that ends in a public Council has earned it. Which mornings are guided in the tail is said before it starts, and no re-thread opens it: the year-scale closing minute already closed the year. Name it to families as intentional: flex plus fallow, not "we'll figure it out." On the last guided day, Thu May 23, say the summer's break words: the one adult is reachable all summer, 988 never closes, the guide is not reachable, the pathway stays live.

For a learner leaving, the Launch is in this stretch, in the third week, on a day set with each learner and their circle, never on a bell and never the last day, because the last day is when the calendar ends and a crossing is not hurried by a calendar; the first week is the Council's fallow. It is a crossing, not a close: the close already happened on the year-close day, and the Log already went out the door that day. The three weeks before it, for a leaving learner, are placement, not new work. Week 1: the Journey view read, alone or with the guide for company, in a walk-in; the credit close-out walked. Week 2: the next-step plan drafted in their own hand or voice, the guide witnessing; the Portrait begun, piece by piece; the circle named with the learner and its shape chosen - the full room, a small room, or one person; and by Thursday the learner's own Growth Record export verified in their hands. This is the gate, and it is checked here, not on the day; if it fails, the learner and the family hear it this week, and the date goes to a family only once it is true. Week 3: the rite told once more in words, the Mantle question named so it has been sat with and is not sprung, and no answer asked for; the gift chosen, or not; the room set; then the Launch, opened by a person, on its day. For a learner staying on, the cycle turns, and the bridge is one sentence: *"You know how to make the hard call. Next year is Origin again: who am I, now?"*

The Launch rite

For a leaving learner, and first of all for the founding tribe, the first ever to complete the full cycle, the Launch is a true rite of passage, built with the three movements every real threshold-crossing has. It is not a graduation that happens *to* you; it is a threshold you *cross through*. A person opens the rite, never the app, because a rite opened by a schedule happens to you; one opened by a person who knows you can be crossed through. The learner has read the whole of it

in Part 1 and here before the day; nothing in it is sprung. It sits in the third week of Open Waters, on a day set with the learner and their circle; the first week is the Council's fallow, and the gate is checked in the second. The Launch is a crossing, not a close: the closing minute was already run on the year-close day, and the grief in the first movement is neither de-roled nor closed with it.

Leaving - the un-belonging. The part everyone skips because it hurts, and skipping it is why so many graduations feel hollow. First, go back through the Growth Record together, in whatever form the learner takes it in, and arrive at where you have been; the Journey view is private, so reading it is the learner's invitation, alone or with the guide for company. Then the grief and the thanks. This is the real work of this part. The ending is named straight out - "this was your home; you are being released from it" - and it is allowed to be sad, held, and not rushed, with a real exit available. Do not use the de-roling move for this grief. De-roling steps you out of a role that was never you. Leaving home is stepping out of a self that truly was you. Never teach a young person to de-role their own real sorrow. For some, leaving here means leaving the steadiest place they have had, for somewhere not yet steady. That is allowed to be more than excitement; the guide holds it as a coach and routes what is bigger.

In between - the threshold, held. No longer a learner, not yet launched. Here the learner is given the Star Chart, the map of where they have been. It is given as a thing to carry over the threshold, not as a slide at a graduation, because this is the exact moment they must steer by it alone. There is a silence around it, and no one fills it; that silence is on purpose. Then the learner makes their next-step plan: their own plan for themselves, in their own hand or voice, with the guide as witness. It is not the studio's plan for them.

Coming in on the far side - the crossing, seen by your people, and a change in how they see you. This is the actual step into adulthood, witnessed by their people. The handoff comes first. The learner makes their Portrait export, piece by piece, and decides who sees it, and takes it. This part cannot be a ceremony over a placeholder, so the real export, in the learner's own hands, must exist before any real learner walks this rite. Then the learner decides what to do with the Mantle: keep it (this is who I am now) or leave it (it belonged to this place). Either choice is true; the choosing is the rite. Then they leave a gift for the room. Then the crossing itself: a doorway, or a line on the floor, that the learner crosses in whatever way they move, while their people watch, into a circle of adults who receive them as an adult and speak to them differently on the far side. The circle is made before the day, with the learner. It can hold their family, a mentor, the one adult outside the room, the adults of the tribe's families, the second adult who sat with us on the heavy days. If their own family is not in it, it is still a full circle, and if they would rather cross with one person than a crowd, it is the same crossing. A rite that does not change how your community sees you is a going-away party. This one changes it. A crossing not made costs nothing; the learner is still launched.

The empty exit. Then the Launch itself: the door closes and stays unlocked from the learner's side. No come-back nudge, ever, because the only proof the door was real is that it stays open from their side only; one nudge turns a launch into a subscription. No campaign to bring them back, no pull on former learners, nothing sold at the door. A launched learner who never returns is a success, not a loss. This is not negotiable under any future pressure.

Leaving a gift for the room

The rite is built around what the learner *takes*, but a threshold is also a community losing a member. So the launched learner leaves one small thing behind that is wholly theirs to give - a word to the next captain, a mark, their Vineyard-thing if they choose. The tribe marks the departure *as a tribe*, not the guide performing it at them - the threshold felt from both sides of the door. For the founding tribe, what they leave becomes the room's first inheritance, so each leaving adds to a line the next group inherits.

The learner with no family in the room is the one this day can let fall. "Crossing witnessed by your people" is the day it falls hardest. Name the tribe as *your people*, in advance and explicitly - the same inclusion floor the whole program holds, applied to the most tender day of all their years here.

What the learner leaves holding: the Growth Record (the backward face - their trail), the next-step plan (the forward face - their plan), and the Captain's Log (their private voice, always theirs, never read for assessment). And the practice they carry inside them - the settle, and the three fixed lines they can run on themselves at a kitchen table at 2 a.m. for the rest of their life.

The arc completes.

"We evoke - we never extract." The honesty is the gift; the container is the care. Held, this year can change a person. That is a hope, not a promise.

The Launch Pad - Studio Year 2029-2030 (Year 3: The Helm)

An operating plan for the 16-18 studio, third year - the culmination Status: v0.2 working draft - built on the 2026-08-24 six-voice upstream safety panel (Bashir, Jake, K'Ehleyr, Ezri, Riker, Kasidy); elevated by the 2026-08-25 five-voice fresh-eyes panel (Kirk, Spock, Guinan, Curzon, Bareil); **+ Ring-1 applied fixes (2026-08-28)** at the end **Year opens:** ~mid-August 2029 (exact calendar mapped like Years 1-2, once the school calendar is set) **Guide:** Erin (solo, with a ~2.5-3-year-old - now enrolled in Vibrant Life Tots, Mon/Wed 9:15-11:30) **Cohort:** 4-7, target 5 - the founding cohort completes the cycle and launches; new learners still join in progress **Shape:** the lighter-guided rhythm (one deep day + one lighter day) carried from The Forge - **plus a required second adult for the three heaviest sessions** (the heaviest material in the three-year arc)

> *Successor in spirit to the Year-2 Forge plan (v0.1). The machine is the same; the content is The Helm - the resolution season, "what do I do when there is no easy answer?" Two things change for Year 3: the material is the heaviest in the whole cycle (moral dilemmas, mortality, imposter/shame work, a public moral Council), and the founding cohort now reaches its launch. The container has to grow to hold both.*

The convergent finding the plan is built on

The six-voice panel was unanimous in shape: **Europa's direction - make The Helm as honest and real as possible for 17/18-year-olds about to enter the real world - is correct and endorsed.** For near-adults three months from adulthood, a padded room would be its own quiet harm: a lie told at the threshold. Keep every word of the honesty.

And the honesty is safe only to the exact degree the *container* is built. Bashir's load-bearing sentence: *depth of material is safe in inverse proportion to how exposed the person is while meeting it*. The trauma floor is not the brake on honesty; it is the suspension that lets the vehicle take rough ground at speed. Jake: *honest-and-held transforms; honest-and-abandoned wounds - the whole verdict is that one word, held.* K'Ehleyr: *honest and real is a somatic promise, not only a curricular one.*

The gap is never the material. It is that the container, this year, is one solo guide holding the heaviest content in the arc. This plan grows the container.

The three decisions this plan is built on (from the panel)

1. **The Helm needs its own "is-this-solo-runnable?" reckoning** - which The Forge got and The Helm had never had. The reckoning's output: the lighter-guided weekly rhythm carries (one deep day, one lighter day), **but the three heaviest sessions require a second adult in the room** - not for childcare, for the room. One adult cannot both hold a moral Council and watch the individual faces for the one learner quietly flooding. Those are two attentional jobs, and in The Helm the material is finally heavy enough that one person cannot do both. (Bashir, Jake, K'Ehleyr - convergent.)

2. **The heaviest material is honest-and-held, never sanitized - and never run without the built floor.** Keep assisted-death allegory, coercion, mortality on the stage, imposter work, the public Council. Build the somatic floor, the live referral pathway, and the Fraud Confession rebuild *before* they run. Honest content, built container.

3. **The founding cohort launches this year - and the Launch is only honest if the record travels.** Use the Compass transcript / Growth Record as the artifact the learner carries out. But the v1 portable export (a real, learner-held PDF at minimum) must exist before any real learner walks the rite - otherwise it is an eviction with a ceremony. (Ezri.)

What The Helm is

Lens: what do I do when there is no easy answer? Joy-flavor: expression & camaraderie. Anchor: "The first duty of every Starfleet officer is to the truth" / the Kobayashi Maru - the test was never how to win, but how to face a no-win scenario without losing yourself.

The arc completes. Origin was **dreaming it** (who am I?); The Forge was **building it** (what is worth solving?); The Helm is **the hard call, and loving the life around it** (what do I do when there is no easy answer?). Self -> world -> the hard call. It is the year a young person learns to reason from principle under genuine uncertainty, live with a hard decision, lead peers, be mentored by the world's adults - and choose life *because* they have looked at hard things.

Signature daily ritual: the **Kobayashi Maru frame** (successor to Origin's choice games and The Forge's Impossible Question) - a no-win scenario faced without losing yourself; the practice of standing inside a dilemma that has no clean answer, long enough to reason from principle rather than reach for the exit.

The Kobayashi Maru at full power (Kirk + Curzon). The famous move - reprogram the simulator, beat the unbeatable test - is the bait, not the lesson. The deeper truth, for near-adults three months from the world: the test is not whether you can find the third option; it is who you are when there is *no* third option. Sometimes the freighter dies. So the year teaches *both halves*:

the discernment to find the third door when it is real (Curzon's Third Chair, S7) **and** the courage to face a genuinely no-win call from principle, name its cost, and not lose yourself carrying it. The highest harvest in the whole three-year arc is not "the learner found the clever way out." It is: *the learner faced a dilemma that could not be won, made the hard call from principle, named what it cost, and did not lose themselves doing it*. S2 (sit in the unwinnable) and S7 (the third option) are reconciled here, not left at war: half the wisdom is finding the third door; the other half is knowing when there isn't one and choosing anyway, with your eyes open.

The year's spine - three through-lines (the v0.2 elevation)

The fresh-eyes panel converged on one finding: the seven sessions are excellent competencies laid end to end, but the *year* reads as a list, not a rising action. Three complementary threads give it a spine - a destination, a carried object, and a living joy - so every session points somewhere and the whole year is one arc, not seven chapters.

1. **Name the destination on day one (Kirk).** On the first day of the year: *"In about thirty-four weeks you will stand before your people and make a hard call in the open - the Council - and some of you will then walk out the door into your own lives - the Launch. Everything between now and then is how you get ready to be worthy of that chair."* Then reasoning (S2) is *how the captain thinks*, empathy (S4) is *how the captain feels the cost*, mentorship (S5) is *learning the terrain from those who walked it*, leadership (S6) is *how the captain holds the room*. Same content; now every session is a rung toward a mountain the learner can already see. Give them the mountain on the first day, and the whole year points.

2. **The Mantle as a physical through-line object (Bareil).** The Mantle is not taken off at the end of S1. It is *taken up* in S1 (lined with the Evidence File), *worn* into the leadership work (S6) and the Council (S7), and at the Launch the learner **decides to keep it or leave it** - the three-year arc of agency (given -> forged -> at the helm) compressed into one authored gesture. One ritual object, one gesture-language, opening in September and closing at the Launch.

3. **The Vineyard - joy that is never made useful (Guinan); planted in Origin, ripening here.** A standing weekly thread running *alongside* the seven sessions, never inside them: each learner tends something they love that has nothing to do with the curriculum (the instrument, the trail, the craft, the friendship, the game), and the cohort simply delights in it together. No Log prompt, no harvest, no developmental purpose spoken aloud. *(MAC/Kirk + Bareil + Ishka, 2026-08-31 - the most-converged MAC finding: the Vineyard is **planted on Origin Day 1 as the twin of the Captain's Log**, not born in the Helm. A returning learner has tended it for up to three years; by the Helm it is old enough to have roots. The Helm is where it ripens - the whole thesis is*

make the hard call **and still love your life**, *and that half of the thesis must not rest on one unprotected Year-3 thread.)* The refusal to make it useful *is* the lesson: this is what the hard calls are *for*. Without it, "love the life around it" is a slogan and the year risks teaching capable young people to steer a ship toward no port. The Vineyard lives on the fallow Friday or the tail of the lighter Tuesday - toddler-shaped, protected, glad. It is also the natural source of the *leaving-a-gift* beat at the Launch (below): the thing a learner loved - tended for years - is the small sovereign gift they leave for the room.

Why this matters (Guinan's hard truth): a resolution season built by trauma-informed voices will, by the gravity of its own care, turn every joyful thing into an instrument of safety - expression became de-roled monologue work, camaraderie became a battle-buddy watch-system. Both are good; neither is joy. The Vineyard is joy given its own home, un-conscripted.

The heavier-container weekly rhythm

Day	Type	Shape
Mon	Self-guided	Learners run their own hours (Erin at Tots 9:15-11:30 with the ~2.5-3yo; check-in ~12:00-12:30)
Tue	**Guided - lighter**	The lighter guided day - the Kobayashi Maru frame, group challenges, theatre-as-play, leadership practice, expedition-prep, the Table - **toddler-flexible by design**
Wed	Self-guided	Learners run their own hours (Erin at Tots, check-in)
Thu	**Guided - deep**	The one deep block of the week - the season's core deliberation, the Socratic dilemma work, the heavy material
Fri	Fallow / hearth	Protected - for learners *and* the guide

The lighter day (Tue) fits a toddler in Tots fine. The deep day (Thu) is the hour that needs the toddler managed - and on the three heaviest weeks, needs a second adult in the room (below).

The three heaviest sessions - the second-adult requirement (the load-bearing gate)

Three of the seven sessions carry material heavy enough that a solo guide cannot both hold the room's deliberation and catch the individual learner who floods. On the deep day of each, **a second adult is required in the room** - not as childcare, as a second pair of eyes whose only job is to leave with the learner who needs to leave, so the guide never has to choose between the room and the wound:

1. **S2 "No Easy Answers"** - the heaviest dilemma episodes (assisted death, coercion/torture, identity-conformity).
2. **S4 "The Stage"** - *Our Town*'s death scene (the one place the season's allegory shield does not apply, because death on the stage *is* the real thing - and a grieving learner takes a direct hit).
3. **S7 "The Council"** - public moral deliberation (exposure on exposure).

The second adult is findable informally, the way The Forge's one-morning coverage was - a trained peer, a co-op parent who has done the safety briefing, the Tots-side adult freed for that hour. Named as a **precondition, not hoped for.** Where a second adult genuinely cannot be secured for a given heavy week, the deep block for that session lightens or defers - the lighter version of the material runs, and the deep version waits until the room can be held. (This is the Guide's Own Floor working, not the guide failing.)

Partial substitute the room itself provides (K'Ehleyr, and it complements but does not replace the second adult): a taught **peer "battle-buddy" pairing** on heavy days - every learner has one other learner assigned to notice them - and a pre-established **physical exit ramp** ("here is where you step out to, and you don't have to ask"). These multiply the room's regulation capacity so the guide is not the only regulator.

The toddler-year model (child now in Tots)

By Year 3 the child is ~2.5-3 and enrolled in Vibrant Life Tots (Mon/Wed 9:15-11:30) - which eases the self-guided days, since the toddler is cared for while Erin is with Tots and the cohort runs its own hours. The residual is the **Tue/Thu guided mornings** (no Tots those days):

1. **Tue (lighter day)** - toddler-flexible by design, as in The Forge.
2. **Thu (deep day), ordinary weeks** - the one deep hour needs the toddler genuinely off the floor (fed/settled before, a light single-morning cover, or off-site that hour) - the same one-morning logic The Forge established. A room-held pause is not childcare and cannot substitute for a deep-material hour.

3. **Thu (deep day), the three heaviest weeks** - the toddler off the floor *and* the second adult present. On these weeks the two needs stack; secure both, or lighten the session.

Named to families: The Helm runs its heaviest material with a second adult and its deep blocks with the toddler cared for - because the founder is raising a young child while guiding the hardest year. Honest, not hidden.

The Guide's Own Floor, amended for Year 3

The Forge amended the floor for structural (not episodic) drain - a weekly presence-check, a load-bearing witness-debrief, permission to lighten the season's shape, capacity -> enrollment -> revenue never the reverse. The Helm adds one thing, because holding assisted-death or coercion allegory *costs the holder*, and the pivot the whole safety floor depends on only works if the guide has the reserve to notice:

- **A per-heavy-session debrief** - after each of the three heaviest deep days, a named debrief with the witness-person before the next heavy session. A depleted guide cannot run the watch-and-pivot. Guide sustainability is not a nicety in Year 3; it is a safety mechanism.
- **Somatic readiness is a guide prerequisite for heavy days** (K'Ehleyr) - a dysregulated guide cannot run the Fraud Confession or *Our Town*. The nervous system reads the guide's autonomic state faster than any lesson plan can counter it.

The safety architecture (built before the season opens)

The somatic floor (K'Ehleyr) - the cognitive floor (allegory, opt-out, reasoning-not-answers) is strong; the somatic floor barely existed (one de-roling ritual carrying the whole heaviest year). Build:

- **A three-scale rhythm on every heavy day:** session-open settle (extend Origin's body-first settle; binding on heavy days - regulate the room *before* activating it) -> mid-work discharge points (30-second orienting between activations, not only at the end) -> session-close return (an active downshift: orient to now, name the hard thing is over, land back in the present).
- **De-roling after every embodiment, with a real mechanic** - not once per season. Say your own name, name three things true about your real life right now ("I am [name], I am 17, it's Tuesday, I have soccer after this"), physically remove the role/prop, shake out the hands, feel the floor.

- **The environment as co-regulator** (the solo-guide substitute) - the pre-set physical exit ramp and the taught peer battle-buddy pairing on every heavy day; titrated group exposure (pairs -> small group -> full circle, paced to the room's daily window, never pushing a dysregulated room to full-circle disclosure).
- **A pre-brief before every flagged-heavy session** - name the terrain, name the exit, name that no reason is owed ("Today's story touches death and the choice to end suffering. You can step out any time, you don't owe anyone a reason, and there's water and a chair by the window"). Arrival, not ambush. The single highest-leverage, lowest-cost addition.

The referral pathway must be LIVE before Session 1 (Bashir) - the coach-not-therapist pathway (built for Year 1) carries, but its one blank must be filled: the **named warm-referral therapist**, arranged, with the quiet space designated and the Day-1 confidentiality script ready. The Helm surfaces clinical material heavier and earlier than any prior year (mortality and assisted-death work reliably surface real grief in a small adolescent cohort - as statistics, not failure). A trauma-informed floor with an unbuilt trap door is not trauma-informed.

The real-learner walk (Bashir + Jake), joint Salus + Jake - the heaviest sessions are walked with a real 17-year-old before they run: the Fraud Confession rebuild, the *Our Town* death scene, the de-roling ritual. My eyes (Jake) for developmental landing, Salus's for the refusability/trauma floor. Jake's standing note, recorded: for material this heavy, he asks the walk not be captain-overridden the way the Discovery mountain gate was.

The seven sessions (run at Helm intensity, with the built container)

#	Session	Shape	The work
1	The Mantle	short	Imposter feelings named as the felt sensation of growth; "Why not you?"; the Evidence File (Year-1 portfolio pulled forward); the Mantle ceremony (worthiness chosen, not earned). *The Fraud Confession is rebuilt - see below.*

#	Session	Shape	The work
2	No Easy Answers	long	Moral dilemmas through TNG allegory tied to real cases (Measure of a Man / Dred Scott; The Drumhead / McCarthyism; The First Duty / whistleblowing). The win is *reasoning*, not the answer. Kohlberg's stages. *Second adult on the heaviest episodes.*
3	The Ripple	short	Consequence-thinking; 2nd/3rd-order effects; the Ripple Board; the Monkey's Paw; the Pre-Mortem. Light, playful, safe.
4	The Stage	long	Theatre as perspective-taking; *Our Town* ("do any human beings ever realize life while they live it?"); monologue work; archetypes-as-doorways; Forum Theatre; the de-roling ritual. *Second adult on the death scene.*
5	The Arena of Voices	short	Real professional mentors + Boise guest speakers; the art of being mentored; the informational interview; the pitch. *Two-track external-adults design - see below.*
6	The Bridge	short	Group leadership; leadership as stewardship not command; rotating command; find-your-captain-style; lead toward your own unnecessity; honor the quiet leaders. Collaborative, safe.
7	The Council	long, harvest	A public deliberation of a real dilemma - reason from principle, name the cost, honor dissent; the Kobayashi Maru move (refuse the binary, find the third option). *Second adult; the somatic Council floor.*

The Fraud Confession, rebuilt (S1) - the one CONTRAINDICATED-as-written item

Bashir and Jake landed here independently and identically: **the word "everyone" is the problem.** "Everyone shares" and "opt-out available" resolve the wrong way in a real room - opting out of a shame ritual, in front of peers, at the age of peak peer-sensitivity, becomes its own shame event. The escape hatch opens onto a second trap. This is a facilitation-structure risk, not a content risk - so the fix is a facilitation rebuild, **not** a HOLD-FOR-HUMAN and **not** co-facilitation:

- **Rename it** (Jake: "the Imposter's Lie" / "Everyone's First Day") - "confession" primes shame and summons a penitent; point the name at the universal feeling, not a personal fraud.
- **The dissolving power comes from adults modeling, learners receiving.** The guide and an invited mentor share, genuinely and specifically. Learners *receive* - that alone accomplishes the goal ("accomplished people feel this too"). No circle-round, no going-around.
- **If a learner shares, it is non-attributed** - written anonymously on cards, read aloud by the guide with no author named ("someone here once felt…"). The wound of shame is in *being seen* as the fraud; anonymity keeps the universality and removes the exposure.
- **Abstention is invisible, not merely permitted** - in a "receive, then optionally write a card" structure, no one can see who chose not to write. That is the only way opt-out is real in a peer room.
- **The Evidence File is sequenced immediately after, same session** - never leave a room having just surfaced shame without building the counterweight (real evidence of competence). Stabilization inside the session, not only across it.
- **S5 mentor-rejection preload** (Jake) - reaching out to an admired professional and being ignored is a real wound at this age; teach "the non-response is not a verdict on you" *before* the outreach, not as consolation after.

The Reasoning Standard - S2's spine (Spock)

"The win is the reasoning, not the answer" is true and *operationally empty* until someone can say what distinguishes strong reasoning from weak without smuggling in a preferred verdict. The method needs guarding at its two failure joints: collapse into relativism ("all positions equally valid") and covert indoctrination (a house answer arrived at as if discovered). The guard is a one-page instrument - the **Reasoning Standard** - five structural questions the *reasoning* must answer, none of which is "what is the right answer":

1. **Principles named.** Which two (or more) genuine goods are in conflict here? *(A "dilemma" with only one real principle is not a dilemma - it may be a rationalized atrocity; say which.)*

2. **Cost owned.** What does your chosen path cost, and to whom? *(Reasoning that claims a free path is hiding the cost.)*
3. **Steelman survived.** Can you state the strongest version of the position you rejected, well enough that its holder would say "yes, that's it"?
4. **Reversibility.** Would you accept this reasoning if you were the stakeholder it costs? *(Universalizability, in the room's grammar - the single most powerful discriminator a 17-year-old has.)*
5. **Framework visible.** Which lens are you reasoning through - consequences, duty, character, care - and what does a *different* lens see that yours does not?

The Standard disciplines the guide as much as the learner: a guide who can only steelman one side has drifted the room toward catechism. Two more S2 rules from Spock: **Kohlberg is a map of available moves, never a ladder that ranks a learner** (stages describe *arguments*, not people; name Kohlberg's own contested limits in the room - the Level-6 move applied to Level 6 itself); and **teach the distinction between a genuine dilemma and a rationalized atrocity** - Dred Scott is the study of how a system reasons itself into evil, not "the other side of a hard call." A curriculum that cannot tell these apart teaches false equivalence; one that teaches learners to tell them apart teaches the season's sharpest blade. Real cases get real-fidelity study (primary voices, the human cost named), or the pairing drops to allegory-only - honor the atrocity or do not borrow its weight.

The Council as a real deliberative form - S7's spine (Curzon)

"They deliberate publicly" is a hope, not a container; without a form, teenagers in front of an audience default to the thing school rehearsed - debate to win. The Council is built as a real form with five parts:

- **Named, rotating roles:** a *convener* (holds the question, not a position), *voices* (argue the live positions in good faith), a *scribe* (writes the reasoning where the room can see it), and a **steward of the absent** (whose only job is "who is affected by this who is not in the room?" - the decision measured at its margins).
- **A six-phase sequence, not a melee:** Frame -> Divergence (surface every position and the fear under it, before anyone argues) -> **Steelman** (each voice states the opposing case well enough that its holder recognizes it) -> the Cost Ledger (name every path's cost and who pays, on the board) -> the Turn (real binary or false one? - the Third Chair) -> the Sense of the Room (where the reasoning arrived, and where it honestly did not).
- **The Steelman made mandatory and physical** - you may not argue your own position until you have voiced the best version of the one you reject. This is how honoring dissent gets built into the bones instead of stapled to the closing remarks. (Forum Theatre from S4 pays off here.)

- **The Third Chair (the false-binary move, made teachable):** an empty chair placed between hardened sides; four questions - what is each side protecting? is the "or" real or inherited? what would honor *both* values at once? and, when there is no third option, choose from principle and carry the grief honestly.
- **A scribe and a board** - the one hook everything hangs on. Reasoning written where all can see becomes the object in the room, not the performers; the exhibition genuinely *is* the thinking. **The strongest unresolved dissent is read into the record in the dissenter's own words and left standing, unrefuted, as part of the harvest** - a good decision carries its dissent forward visibly.
- **Consecrate and release (Bareil):** a marked opening that says "this is not ordinary talk," and - hardest and most important - a **closing that completes the council without resolving the dilemma** ("we did not solve it; we reasoned honestly, together, in front of our people; the council is closed"). That release lets a young person carry an unresolved hard thing without it becoming an open wound.

Real stakes without a verdict (Kirk): let the Council deliberate something with actual consequence to Vibrant Life or Boise - a real policy, a real trade-off the community faces - so the reasoning matters because it is *used*, not because it is *graded*. And S6 must add **rotating *facilitation*, not just command** (Curzon) - every learner takes the convener's chair for a low-stakes real disagreement and practices holding the question without answering it. Command teaches you to sit in the chair; facilitation teaches you to hold the room from beside it, and S7 needs the second.

External adults - the two-track design (S5 + guest speakers)

Season Three opens the closed system to the world's adults - which is exactly right for a 17-year-old about to launch. It opens two holes in the perimeter, and they are not the same size. **A guest speaker is a window; a 1:1 mentor is a door** (Riker). Secure them differently.

Track 1 - Boise guest speakers (the window): BUILD, solo-runnable with a modest policy

- **Guide present for the entire visit** (this alone satisfies the never-alone rule); public/observable setting; a short expectations sheet the speaker acknowledges (topic scope, no private contact exchanged with learners, no photos without consent); parent notification of who and when. **No background check required** for a one-time supervised group speaker - the supervision *is* the control, and requiring checks would kill the ability to bring interesting people in.
- **Watch the conversion point:** a speaker who starts contacting a learner afterward has walked through the door without being vetted for it - route any follow-up through the guide, which converts them to the mentor track.

Track 2 - 1:1 professional mentors (the door): BUILD-WITH-CONDITIONS, not cleared to launch until the infrastructure exists

Riker's gates (all binding, mentor track): **observable channel only** (no private DMs / personal social media / off-platform; the guide sees the existence and cadence of contact, never the content for assessment); **never-alone satisfied structurally** (default remote-and-monitored; in-person only with Erin present or a public setting - never a private residence or vehicle); **background check** via an external screening process before first contact; **three-party informed consent** (parent, learner, mentor) + **signed boundaries**; a **no-fault off-ramp** (a learner ends or reports a match with one word to Erin, no reason owed, no confrontation); a **written safeguarding + mandatory-reporting policy** authored once, on paper, before the first match; and **counsel review** of Idaho duty-of-care, mandatory reporting, and liability/insurance (same routing as the teen-sandbox §7 crux).

Kasidy's reciprocity floor (so we honor givers, not mine them for "inspiration"): **pay real honoraria** + cover costs (a waived fee is accepted only if freely offered, never solicited); offer a **menu of depths** - one informational interview / a short arc / a sustained 1:1 - with **the one-off honored identically to the year-long mentorship** (no ranking the givers; refusal #5 turned toward the adults); **bounded terms + a dignified no-fault exit**; **the teen arrives prepared** (the "art of being mentored" as a precondition - a good question is the reciprocal gift); **close the loop** (genuine thanks, tell the giver what their gift did, ask whether it served *them*); **the story is a gift, never the price** (a professional's hard call - especially a trauma-proximate one - is invited freely, never required as content); **continuity over churn** (build the network to compound toward the givers across years - eventually, learners who were mentored returning to mentor); and **the mentor is not the load-bearing safeguarding adult** (keep that boundary bright; route weight it wasn't built for to the guide).

Ordering (non-negotiable): Riker builds the container first; then Kasidy's reciprocity design; George costs the honoraria and does the reciprocal outreach to Boise professional communities (build through communities that already hold relationship, not cold extraction); Kira/Stirps if the network touches refugee or immigrant communities (the Closing Feast cultural-respect gate travels with it).

The Launch - the founding cohort completes the cycle (Ezri's Q3)

The Launch is the Next Great Adventure rite (off-cycle, overlaid on the learner's final season). The formation is built to prepare it for three full years - The Helm *is* the preparation (mentor matching, rotating leadership toward one's own unnecessity, the Council where the exhibition is

the reasoning not a verdict). The exit is honestly un-trapped already: a launched learner who never returns is a success, not churn; there is no come-back nudge, no re-engagement campaign, no adult-upsell at the threshold. Good - keep it.

Use the Compass transcript / Growth Record - it is the right artifact and the direct answer to the Year-1 "eviction with a ceremony" flag. Its architecture is the answer: *the app is a lens, not the vault* - the learner holds the keys from day one, the guide is a guest whose access ends when the relationship does, and the platform cannot strand a record it never held.

The binding condition (Ezri): in built code the record does not yet travel - the v1 portable export (a real, human-readable, learner-held PDF at minimum) is unbuilt. **The Launch rite may not be walked by a real learner until that v1 export exists.** A rite whose central promise ("this is yours, you carry it out") resolves to a placeholder is the exact extraction we forbid. The founding cohort does not reach The Helm until 2029-2030, so the runway exists; build the export in that window against the founder/test path before then.

What the 18-year-old walks out holding - three artifacts: 1. **The Growth Record (the backward face)** - the nine-year trail. The *Portrait view* (verified, competency-framed, selectively disclosed) is what they hand a college or employer; the *Journey view* stays private. Must travel. 2. **The next-step document (the forward face)** - crafted in the guide 1-on-1, learner-authored / guide-witnessed. Their plan for themselves, not the studio's plan for them. 3. **The Captain's Log (their private voice)** - theirs, always was, never read for assessment. *Open item: decide where the Log physically lives and how it leaves* (a physical notebook is the cleanest sovereignty story - already in their hands, needs no export).

The Launch built as a true rite of passage (Bareil + Guinan + Ezri)

The fresh-eyes panel's hardest finding: the most weight in the whole three-year design rests on its thinnest container. The Launch - the single most important threshold in nine years - was one line. Build it as a real rite of passage, with the three movements every enduring threshold-crossing has, or it will feel like a graduation (a ceremony that happens *to* you, not one you *cross through*):

1. **Separation - the un-belonging.** The part everyone skips because it hurts, and skipping it is why so many graduations feel hollow and so many young adults feel they never really left. A moment that names the leaving directly: *this was your home; you are being released from it*. The **grief-and-gratitude beat lives here** as the *work* of this phase, not decoration - grief is the honest cost of having belonged to something worth grieving. *Caution (Guinan):* do **not** borrow the de-roling mechanic for this grief. De-roling steps you out of a role that was never you; leaving home is stepping out of a self

that absolutely *was* you. Never teach a young person to de-role their own real sorrow. Let it be tender, held, unrushed, with a real exit (coach-not-therapist holds; a learner leaving an unstable home for an uncertain future is not only excited).

2. **Liminality - the threshold, held.** The between-space, no-longer-a-learner and not-yet-launched. The **Star Chart is revealed here as a threshold-object, not a graduation slide** - the map of where they have been, given at the exact moment they must navigate by it alone, with a silence around it that no one fills. The between-space is where the soul does its work.

3. **Reincorporation - the crossing, witnessed, with a change of standing.** The actual step into adulthood, seen by their people, across a literal threshold (a doorway, a line stepped over), Log in hand, into a circle of adults who **receive them as an adult and address them differently on the far side.** A rite that does not change your standing in your community's eyes is a going-away party. The **Captain's Log handoff** is the return-object and the reincorporation gesture ("it is yours; take it; no copy kept"). And the learner **decides what to do with the Mantle** - keep it (this is who I am now) or leave it (it belonged to this place) - either choice true, the *choosing* being the rite, the three-year arc of agency in one gesture.

Leaving a gift (Guinan). The rite is built around what the learner *takes*; a threshold is also a community losing a member. The launched learner **leaves one small, sovereign thing behind for the room** - a word to the next captain, a mark, their Vineyard-thing - and the **cohort marks the departure *as a cohort*** (not the guide performing it at them). The threshold felt from both sides of the door. For the founding cohort - the first ever to complete the cycle - what they leave becomes the room's first inheritance, turning a series of departures into a lineage.

The family-less learner is most exposed here - "crossing witnessed by your people" is the day the young person with no people falls hardest. Name the tribe as *your people*, in advance and explicitly - the same inclusion floor the Unveiling and Closing Feast hold, applied to the most tender day of nine years.

The Launch rite, sequenced (structure now, copy later, with the cohort): guide opens the rite (never the system) -> **SEPARATION:** look back and read the Growth Record together (arrive at where you've been) + the grief-and-gratitude beat (the release, held, unrushed) -> **LIMINALITY:** the Dome opens, the Star Chart given as a threshold-object in silence -> craft the next-step document -> **REINCORPORATION:** the handoff (generate the Portrait export, choose its visibility, take it - this beat cannot be ceremony over a placeholder) + the Mantle keep-or-leave choice + leaving a gift for the room + the witnessed crossing into a circle that receives them as an adult -> the Launch (the door closes and stays unlocked from her side; no come-back nudge).

Cohort & rotation

- **One season live at a time.** The founding cohort completes The Helm and launches. Do not run simultaneous seasons (not operable solo).
- **New 16-18s still join in progress** - the cycle/line model; they ride once fully around before they launch. Note: The Helm is *not* the kindest season to enter cold (its material is the heaviest) - a joiner arriving straight into The Helm needs care, the joiner scaffold, and possibly a lighter first pass at the heaviest sessions until they have a season's trust.
- **Cohort 4-7, target 5.** Grow toward 7 only if the deep-hour coverage *and* the heavy-session second adult are genuinely secured. Capacity -> enrollment -> revenue, never the reverse.
- **Mixed-age is still a gift** - but the refusals hold hardest in the heaviest year; watch that the graduating captains' weight does not set a ceiling the younger learners measure against.

The child in the room's orbit, named as curriculum-lived (Jake)

A cohort about to launch into adulthood, with a toddler in the building's orbit, is shown - structurally, without a lesson - what a whole adult life looks like. The Helm's own thread is "make the hard call *and* love the life around it - tend the vineyard, play the flute, love your crew." A founder guiding a moral Council in the morning and parenting a three-year-old the same season *is that thread made flesh*. Named rightly (curriculum lived, not the guide's burden), it is developmentally generative for near-adults deciding whether an examined, principled, loving life is actually livable - *but only if the shape is genuinely sustainable*. A fraying guide teaches the opposite lesson. This is why the container work above is not overhead; it is the curriculum.

What carries unchanged from Years 1-2

The six refusals; the Captain's Log thread; the self-management scaffold + per-learner readiness; the HS-credit rule (core credits completed by the learner's final year if high on their journey); the Table (inclusion floor); the coach-not-therapist referral pathway (built Year 1 - now with the therapist named, per above); the Two-Way Deal / discussion culture; the accessibility doors; the fallow Friday; the joiner scaffold (Fast-Origin seed, Log day one, peer-witness pairing, shared threshold); the returner reach-back.

Preconditions to open (Year 3) - the gates, binding

1. **The Fraud Confession rebuilt** (S1) before it runs - "everyone shares" killed; adults-model / learners-receive; non-attributed if shared; abstention invisible; Evidence File sequenced after; renamed.
2. **A second adult secured for the three heaviest sessions** (S2 heaviest episodes, S4 *Our Town*, S7 Council) - named, not hoped; where unsecured for a given week, the session lightens or defers.
3. **The somatic floor built** - three-scale rhythm, de-roling-every-embodiment, environment-as-co-regulator (exit ramp + battle-buddy), heavy-session pre-brief.
4. **The referral pathway LIVE** before Session 1 - the named warm-referral therapist arranged, quiet space designated, Day-1 confidentiality script ready.
5. **The joint Salus + Jake real-learner walk** of the heaviest live content - before the cohort meets those sessions; Jake asks it not be overridden.
6. **The Guide's Own Floor, Helm-amended** - per-heavy-session debrief; somatic readiness as a heavy-day guide prerequisite; witness-debrief named and load-bearing before the season opens.
7. **Guest-speaker policy** (expectations sheet + parent notification) before the first speaker - solo-runnable.
8. **The mentor-track infrastructure** before the first 1:1 match - observable channel, background-check process, three-party consent + signed boundaries, off-ramp, written safeguarding + mandatory-reporting policy, **counsel review** (Idaho duty-of-care + liability/insurance). Not this season's decoration; its foundation.
9. **The Growth Record v1 portable export built and verified** before any real learner walks the Launch rite.
10. Carries from Years 1-2: the counsel ruling on Mon/Wed presence; the whole-absence bench; the coach-not-therapist pathway (built).

Notes and open items

- **Calendar** - map the 2029-2030 dates and holiday observances like Years 1-2, once the school calendar is set.
- **Which guide-day is deep** (here: Thu) is adjustable to whichever morning the coverage + second adult are easiest.
- **Guide-day weekday - RESOLVED (Ring-1):** the three-year spec now reads Tue/Thu; the standing contradiction is closed.
- **The founder's margin** - weigh whatever else 2029-2030 holds for the family against even this container; the "defer the heaviest sessions" option stays honorable, and a further-lightened season is the floor working, not the guide failing. **Ring-1: the *lighter***

Helm is the default first pass - full-intensity S2/S4/S7 is opt-*in* by readiness for a later cohort (after the container has been run once and the child is older), never opt-*out* by exhaustion.

- **Where the Captain's Log physically lives** and how it leaves - resolve (a physical notebook is the cleanest).
- **The real-world residuals** that gate *running*, not designing: the named therapist, the mentor background-check process + written policy + counsel review, and the Growth Record v1 export. Track these as build work with owners.

The Life Admin strand this year (The Helm's exposure-days + the launch sweep)

The cross-year Life Admin strand (do-it-for-real, just-in-time; see `launch-pad-life-admin-strand-v0.1.md`) places a light exposure-touch on its items across all three years. **The Helm carries the launch-critical, legally-adult, threshold items** - and the sweep that ensures nothing was missed: - **Health coverage** (the aging-off transition; decode the jargon; urgent care vs ER). - **Renting** (read a real lease; tenant rights; the deposit wall; renters insurance). - **The launch-year sweep** - confirm every item on the eight-item Launch Floor has been met at the exposure layer, and invite the deeper do-it-for-real dive; a learner may decline a dive **with a reasoned why** (the guide questions Socratically, never vetoes). Offered as care, part of being handed the keys - never graded. - **Deeper dives** on anything not yet done for real, pulled just-in-time as the launch approaches.

This threads into the Launch rite itself (the Growth Record handoff; the readiness map as a record of reasoned choices). Placement, the Launch Floor, and the engagement model live in the strand spec; this is the cross-reference.

Ring-1 applied fixes (2026-08-28) - The Helm's share

The three-year spec carries the canonical Ring-1 doctrine (its "Ring-1 revisions" section); the Helm's concrete applications - the heaviest year, so the safety fixes concentrate here:

- **Scaffolding vs floor - titrate the signal, hold the floor (SSC ruling).** The Helm's stacked container was found to over-*signal* ("we expect you to break"). Titrate the *reassurance signal* - reframe every net as legible trust, not vigilance (the battle-buddy is "a crew that holds each other," never "assigned to watch you flood"); thin the reassurance as the cohort's trust matures. But **hold the floor's actual availability whole** - the exit ramp, discharge/return, de-roling after every embodiment, the second adult on the three

heaviest sessions are non-negotiable and are named un-cuttable *in the same breath as the referral pathway* (a tired guide cuts de-roling first because it feels like overhead - it is the floor).

- **The harden-off, RESEATED (SSC/COC ruling; the PDC's proposal refused as posed).** A learner meeting a hard thing *un-held* before launch is a real and good goal - but grief and moral injury do not "harden off" (that is the frost, not the bracing morning). So it is **refused on the heaviest material (S2/S4/S7), where the floor stays whole**, and reseated onto ordinary-stakes surfaces that are *meant* to be crossed alone: the absent-guide day, the real bureaucracy call, mentor rejection, the no-win case. There, reduce the *visible scaffold* (not the floor's availability), on *medium-weight* material, *chosen and named* never sprung, age/tenure gated (launching 17-18s in their final season only; contraindicated for under-16 / first-season / already-over-hardened learners - Kira).
- **The closing practice reaches its culmination here.** The learner-held closing/re-crossing practice, seeded in Origin and spiraled, is what the graduate carries out the door to close their own openings after the guide is gone; the Launch rite's Separation -> Liminality -> Reincorporation is the arc-scale instance of it. The design opens faster than it closes - this is the year the closing capacity must be *theirs*.
- **The export is Tier-3 - binding before Aug 2029, not now (Vuna Aris / Miles).** The Growth Record v1 portable export remains a hard gate on walking the Launch rite, but it is *cold infrastructure built off the guide, before the run-year* - not a present-day burden. "Do not power on any run-year whose build-list still contains cold infrastructure."
- **The guide is the floor (carried from the spec doctrine):** the cross-year sustainability watch (SSC/Bashir, held externally) and the pre-dated defer blessing govern the Helm year most of all, since this is where the load and the content are heaviest.

"We evoke - we never extract." - the honesty is the gift; the container is the care. Held, this season transforms.

Launch Pad Year 3 (The Helm) - Session 1 “The Mantle” - Day by Day

Status: v0.2 working draft (fresh-eyes elevation; + Ring-1 seeds 2026-08-28) | **When:** weeks 1-3 (short session; opens the year) **Companions:** Year 3 studio-year plan (Helm); three-year spec (Season Three); coach-not-therapist referral pathway

The session at a glance

- **Arc:** OPEN (imposter feeling, named) -> DEEPEN (“Why not you?”; the Evidence File; a real act that scares you) -> HARVEST (the Mantle rite - worthiness claimed, not earned).
- **The thread:** *imposter feeling is the felt sensation of reaching past your current competence toward the self you are becoming. It is a signal of growth, not a defect. You do not wait to feel ready; you take up the mantle, and the feeling of worthiness follows the acting*.
- **The frame to teach (simply):** the imposter’s lie is “everyone else belongs here and I snuck in.” The truth is that accomplished people feel it too - and it fades not by proving yourself but by acting anyway.
- **Ring-1 seed (2026-08-28):** imposter/shame work is an *opening* - so the Closing Practice (now three years old for returners; `launch-pad-closing-practice-v0.1.md`) closes it, and reaches its arc-scale culmination this year. The Mantle is *held*, not a harden-off surface - the un-held-encounter work lives on ordinary-stakes surfaces (S3/S5/S6), never on the identity/shame material.
- **The Mantle is the year’s through-line object (Bareil).** It is *not* taken off at the end of this session. It is taken up here (lined with the Evidence File), worn into the leadership work (S6) and the Council (S7), and at the Launch the learner decides to keep it or leave it. One ritual object, opening in September and closing at the Launch.
- **The Vineyard comes to fruition here (Guinan) and runs all year** - *planted in Origin as the twin of the Captain’s Log (MAC/Kirk, 2026-08-31 - it is not born in the Helm; a returning learner has tended it for up to three years, and even a Helm-entry joiner met it in their Fast-Origin seed)* - a standing weekly thread (fallow Friday or the tail of the lighter Tuesday) where each learner tends something they love that has nothing to do with the curriculum, and the cohort delights in it together. No Log prompt, no harvest, no purpose spoken aloud. Re-name it in Week 1: “this is the part of the week that is yours to love” - and this year it ripens into the *gift left for the room* at the Launch. It is what the hard calls are *for*.

- **Helm rhythm:** Tue guided-lighter (imposter games, “Why not you?”, the Evidence File build - toddler-flexible), Thu guided-deep (the Mantle work and rite). Mon/Wed self-guided; Fri fallow.

Care points

- **This is the rebuilt session.** The old “Fraud Confession - everyone shares” is gone. Shame and imposter feeling are not the same emotion: imposter feeling (“I don’t belong here yet”) is generative; public shame disclosure in a peer group can wound lastingly. The dissolving power comes from *adults modeling, learners receiving* - not from any learner being required to confess. (Bashir + Jake, independently identical.)
- **The rebuilt structure (BINDING):** the guide and an invited mentor share genuinely and specifically (“here is a time I felt like a fraud”). Learners *receive* - that alone teaches “accomplished people feel this too.” No circle-round, no going-around. If a learner wishes to share, it is **non-attributed** (written on a card, read aloud by the guide with no author named: “someone here once felt…”). **Abstention is invisible** - in a receive-then-optionally-write-a-card structure, no one can see who chose not to write. That is the only real opt-out in a peer room.
- **The Evidence File is sequenced immediately after, same session** - never leave a room having surfaced shame without building the counterweight (real evidence of competence). Stabilization inside the session, not only across it.
- **The Mantle as a true rite, not a game (Bareil).** A game can be replayed; a rite crosses you once. The Mantle rite has four movements: **Threshold** (before the cloak, the learner names *aloud, in their own words*, what they are taking up - “I am someone who can hold a hard call” - claimed, not conferred; speaking it while not yet believing it *is* the rite); **Witness** (a named witness at the instant of crossing reflects it back: “I saw you take that up”); **Return-object** (the Evidence File is the cloak’s lining - put it on, find in its pocket the proof you have already done hard things); **Reincorporation** (the mantle is *not* removed at day’s end - it becomes the year’s through-line). Guard the order of any modeling so the confession is never the price of admission to the Mantle; the evidence of worth must be reachable by the learner who cannot confess.
- **Worthiness follows the *acting* (Guinan) - add a real act.** Imposter feeling does not dissolve by being told it is universal; the thread says worthiness follows the acting. So Week 2 includes a real, chosen act that scares the learner a little - take a real chair, make a real call, ship a real thing - and discover the worthiness on the far side. Receiving evidence is not enough; the session must include *doing*.
- **Somatic care:** shame lives in the body (dorsal-vagal collapse - heat, dropped gaze, curled spine). Open with the settle; keep the exposure titrated (receive first, low-stakes); close with a return. A learner who dips into shame needs the room to catch it as normal, and a physical exit ramp they can use without asking.

- Coach-not-therapist carries: a genuine shame disclosure can shade toward “past coaching” - the referral pathway is live before this session runs.

Week 1 - OPEN (imposter feeling, named)

- **Mon - Self-guided** - core / HS credits; the season opens - what does “I don’t belong here yet” feel like for you? (private, in the Log). Check-in ~12:00.
- **Tue - Guided (lighter)** - **name the destination (Kirk):** “in about thirty-four weeks you make a hard call in the open - the Council - and some of you walk out into your own lives - the Launch; everything between now and then gets you ready to be worthy of that chair.” The Kobayashi Maru frame introduced as the year’s ritual - **and named as the same muscle they have built all along** (Origin’s choice games -> the Forge’s Impossible Question -> the Helm’s no-win call: make small choices, then stand inside questions too big to close, now make the hard call inside a no-win); imposter feeling named as universal and as a *growth signal*; light games that surface the lie without demanding disclosure. **The Vineyard re-opens** (planted in Origin) - “the part of the week that is yours to love.” *Toddler-flexible.*
- **Wed - Self-guided** - core; where in your life are you reaching past your current competence? Log. Check-in.
- **Thu - Guided (deep)** - the guide and an invited mentor model imposter feeling (genuine, specific); learners receive; the frame lands (“accomplished people feel it too”). Optional non-attributed cards. Bridge: begin your Evidence File.
- **Fri - Fallow / hearth.**

Week 2 - DEEPEN (“Why not you?” + the Evidence File)

- **Mon - Self-guided** - core; gather evidence of your competence (work, moments, others’ words); Log. Check-in.
- **Tue - Guided (lighter)** - “Why not you?” - the question turned from doubt to permission; build the Evidence File together (the Year-1 portfolio pulled forward - the cycle paying off). *Toddler-flexible.*
- **Wed - Self-guided** - core; add to your Evidence File; name one place you have been waiting to feel ready - and choose a real act to do this week that scares you a little. Log. Check-in.
- **Thu - Guided (deep)** - the gap between feeling ready and being ready; worthiness is chosen, not earned; act-before-you-feel-it - each learner names (and begins) their real, chosen act and discovers the worthiness on the far side. Bridge: what mantle are you ready to take up?
- **Fri - Fallow / hearth.**

Week 3 - HARVEST (the Mantle ceremony)

- **Mon - Self-guided** - core; name the mantle you are taking up this year; Log. Check-in.
- **Tue - Guided (lighter)** - prepare the ceremony together; the cohort as witnesses (warm, not evaluative). *Toddler-flexible*.
- **Wed - Self-guided** - final prep; rest. Check-in.
- **Thu - THE MANTLE (the four-movement rite)** - **Threshold:** each learner names aloud, in their own words, what they are taking up (claimed, not conferred). **Return-object:** they put on the mantle and find the Evidence File as its lining - proof they have already done hard things (including this week's real act). **Witness:** a named witness reflects the crossing back ("I saw you take that up"). **Reincorporation:** the mantle is *not* taken off - it becomes the year's through-line, worn toward the Council and the Launch. *Being seen is a gift, never a demand; the learner who cannot speak it aloud may claim it in writing, equally*. Bridge into Session 2 (No Easy Answers): *"You have taken up the mantle. Now: the hard calls it will ask of you."*
- **Fri - Fallow / hearth - closes Session 1.**

"We evoke - we never extract."

Launch Pad Year 3 (The Helm) - Session 2 “No Easy Answers” - Day by Day

Status: v0.2 working draft (fresh-eyes elevation; + Ring-1 seeds 2026-08-28) | **When:** weeks 4-9 (long session, 6 weeks) **Companions:** Year 3 studio-year plan (Helm); Helm Session 1; three-year spec (Season Three); coach-not-therapist referral pathway

The session at a glance

- **Arc:** OPEN (a dilemma has no answer key) -> DEEPEN (real moral dilemmas through allegory; Kohlberg’s stages) -> APPLY (reason a dilemma through, out loud, from principle) -> HARVEST (a reasoned position on a hard case - held, not “won”).
- **The thread:** *the world does not hand you the answer key. The win is not the right answer; it is the quality of the reasoning and the honesty about the cost. You learn to stand inside a dilemma long enough to reason from principle rather than reach for the exit.*
- **What “the captain thinks” - S2’s place in the year (Kirk):** this is how the captain who will hold the Council (S7) learns to reason. Name it: the reasoning built here is what you will stand on at the year’s end.
- **Ring-1 seed (2026-08-28):** this is one of the three heaviest sessions - **NO harden-off here; the floor stays whole** (second adult, somatic floor, opt-out all intact). Titrate the *reassurance signal* if it over-announces (“legible trust, not vigilance”), never the floor’s availability. The dilemma work is an opening; close it with the Closing Practice (the affective twin of the Reasoning Standard that is this session’s spine).
- **The method:** moral dilemmas through TNG allegory tied to real cases - Measure of a Man / Dred Scott (personhood); The Drumhead / McCarthyism (due process under fear); The First Duty / whistleblowing (loyalty vs truth). Kohlberg’s stages named as a map, not a ladder to climb for a grade.
- **The Reasoning Standard (Spock) is the spine of this session** - the instrument that makes reasoning assessable without ever assessing the verdict (below). The Vineyard runs alongside all six weeks.
- **Helm rhythm:** Tue guided-lighter (dilemma games, the reasoning craft, Kohlberg map - toddler-flexible), Thu guided-deep (the heavy dilemma work). Mon/Wed self-guided; Fri fallow.

The Reasoning Standard (Spock) - assess the reasoning, never the verdict

Five structural questions the *reasoning* must answer. None is "what is the right answer." Use it to coach, to self-assess, and (in S7) to witness - and hold the guide to it too (a guide who can only steelman one side has drifted the room toward catechism): 1. **Principles named** - which two-plus genuine goods conflict here? *(One real principle only = not a dilemma; may be a rationalized atrocity - say which.)* 2. **Cost owned** - what does your path cost, and to whom? *(A "free" path is a hidden cost.)* 3. **Steelman survived** - can you state the rejected position well enough that its holder says "yes, that's it"? 4. **Reversibility** - would you accept this reasoning if you were the stakeholder it costs? 5. **Framework visible** - consequences / duty / character / care - and what does a different lens see that yours misses?

Two guardrails (Spock): Kohlberg is a map of moves, never a rank of persons - stages describe *arguments*, not learners; name Kohlberg's own contested limits in the room (the Level-6 move applied to Level 6 itself). And **teach the distinction between a genuine dilemma and a rationalized atrocity** - some paired cases are real dilemmas (mandatory minimums, the bomb, whistleblowing); some are not (Dred Scott is how a system reasons itself into evil, not "the other side"). Teaching learners to tell them apart is the season's sharpest blade. **Real-case fidelity:** the paired atrocity gets genuine study (primary voices, the human cost named) or the pairing drops to allegory-only. Honor the reality, or do not borrow its weight.

Care points (this is one of the three heaviest sessions)

- **SECOND ADULT REQUIRED on the heaviest deep days** (the assisted-death, coercion, and identity-conformity episodes) - not childcare; a second pair of eyes whose only job is to leave with the learner who needs to leave, so the guide never chooses between the room and the wound. Where a second adult cannot be secured for a given heavy week, that deep block lightens or defers.
- **Allegory is the safety technology, not the watered-down version.** Data's trial lets a room reason about personhood and slavery at full weight while each learner's own unhealed places stay behind the glass. Keep the allegory; it is what makes maximum honesty survivable.
- **Preview-and-alternate the heaviest episodes** - *Ethics* (assisted death), *Chain of Command* (coercion/torture), *The Outcast* (identity/conformity). Alternates pre-selected before the day, not improvised. Name the terrain and the exit in the pre-brief.

- **Honest about the world, only-as-deep-as-chosen about the self.** The dilemma can be unflinching; the learner's own interior is never required as material. Dilemmas resolve into *reasoning*, never "the right answer" - the most honest choice, because it tells the truth about the world they are entering.
- **Somatic floor:** open settle -> mid-work discharge points (30-sec orienting between activations) -> close return, every heavy day. Pre-brief before every flagged episode (arrival, not ambush). Battle-buddy pairing and a physical exit ramp in place before the heavy material opens.
- Coach-not-therapist carries; the referral pathway is live.

Week 4 - OPEN (a dilemma has no answer key)

- **Mon - Self-guided** - core / HS credits; a real decision you have faced with no clean right answer - what made it hard? Log. Check-in.
- **Tue - Guided (lighter)** - what a moral dilemma is (vs a problem with a solution); the reasoning craft; Kohlberg's stages as a map of *how* people reason, not a rank. *Toddler-flexible.*
- **Wed - Self-guided** - core; watch/read the week's allegory case; note where you land and why. Log. Check-in.
- **Thu - Guided (deep)** - Measure of a Man / personhood (Dred Scott alongside): who counts as a person, and who decides? Reason from principle *through the Reasoning Standard*. Name plainly that Dred Scott is not "the other side of a dilemma" - it is how a system reasoned itself into evil (the dilemma-vs-atrocity distinction, taught live). Bridge: whose reasoning changed yours?
- **Fri - Fallow / hearth.**

Week 5 - DEEPEN (due process under fear)

- **Mon - Self-guided** - core; the week's case; where does fear distort judgment? Log. Check-in.
- **Tue - Guided (lighter)** - dilemma games; how a good process protects a hard call; steelmanning the side you disagree with. *Toddler-flexible.*
- **Wed - Self-guided** - core; a time fear shaped a group's decision (allegorical or historical); Log. Check-in.
- **Thu - Guided (deep)** - The Drumhead / McCarthyism: due process when a room is afraid. Reason from principle. Bridge: what protects the accused when everyone is certain?
- **Fri - Fallow / hearth.**

Week 6 - DEEPEN (loyalty vs truth)

- **Mon - Self-guided** - core; the week's case; when is loyalty a virtue and when a trap? Log. Check-in.
- **Tue - Guided (lighter)** - the reasoning craft continues; the cost of every choice named honestly. *Toddler-flexible*.
- **Wed - Self-guided** - core; a hard call between loyalty and truth; Log. Check-in.
- **Thu - Guided (deep)** - The First Duty / whistleblowing: the first duty is to the truth. Reason from principle; name what it costs. Bridge: toward the heaviest cases, previewed.
- **Fri - Fallow / hearth.**

Weeks 7-8 - APPLY (the heaviest cases - previewed, alternated, second adult)

Each week, same shape - **second adult present on the deep day:** - **Mon / Wed - Self-guided** - core; the previewed case (alternate available, no reason owed); reason it through in the Log. Check-in. - **Tue - Guided (lighter)** - the reasoning craft; process the *reasoning*, not personal disclosure. *Toddler-flexible*. - **Thu - Guided (deep), pre-briefed** - the heaviest episodes across the two weeks (*Ethics* / assisted death; *Chain of Command* / coercion; *The Outcast* / identity-conformity), each with its alternate. Allegory-first; opt-out with no reason owed; reason from principle. Bridge: hold the tension without resolving it. - **Fri - Fallow / hearth.**

Week 9 - HARVEST (a reasoned position, held not won)

- **Mon - Self-guided** - core; choose a dilemma; write your reasoned position *against the five questions of the Reasoning Standard* (principles named, cost owned, steelman survived, reversibility, framework visible); Log. Check-in.
- **Tue - Guided (lighter)** - share reasoning (not verdicts); the room practices honoring a well-reasoned position it disagrees with. *Toddler-flexible*.
- **Wed - Self-guided** - core; refine your position; Log. Check-in.
- **Thu - Guided (deep): HARVEST** - a reasoned position on a hard case, held from principle, not "won." *Empty-basket honored: "I reasoned my way to 'I still do not know' - and here is why" is a real and honest harvest*. Bridge into Session 3 (The Ripple): *"You can reason a hard call. Now: trace what it sets in motion."*
- **Fri - Fallow / hearth - closes Session 2.**

"We evoke - we never extract."

Launch Pad Year 3 (The Helm) - Session 3 “The Ripple” - Day by Day

Status: v0.2 working draft (fresh-eyes elevation; + Ring-1 seeds 2026-08-28) | **When:** weeks 10-12 (short session; a lighter beat after S2) **Companions:** Year 3 studio-year plan (Helm); Helm Sessions 1-2; three-year spec (Season Three)

The session at a glance

- **Arc:** OPEN (every choice sends ripples) -> DEEPEN (2nd- and 3rd-order effects; the Pre-Mortem) -> HARVEST (a decision traced forward, ripples named).
- **The thread:** *a hard call does not end when you make it. It sets things in motion - some you intend, some you do not. Consequence-thinking is looking one, two, three moves downstream before you act - and being honest that you cannot see all the way.*
- **The tools:** the Ripple Board (map the downstream effects of a choice), the Monkey’s Paw (the wish granted with a twist - unintended consequences as story), counterfactual history (what if this one thing had gone differently?), the Pre-Mortem (imagine the choice failed - why?).
- **Helm rhythm:** Tue guided-lighter (what-if games, the Ripple Board, the Monkey’s Paw - toddler-flexible), Thu guided-deep (the Pre-Mortem and second/third-order reasoning). Mon/Wed self-guided; Fri fallow.
- **Deliberately lighter and playful** - a breath between the two heaviest sessions (S2 and S4). Safe by design; no second adult needed.
- **Ring-1 seed (2026-08-28) - a home for the reseated harden-off.** Because this is medium-weight and safe, it is one of the ordinary-stakes surfaces where the *harden-off* rightly lives (reseated off the heavy material, per the SSC/COC ruling): a hard consequence-call met with the *ordinary* supports (guide present, exit available) rather than the full scaffold - chosen and named, never sprung, gated to the ready launch-year learner. Reduce the visible scaffold, never the floor’s availability. Carry the Closing Practice and Vineyard.
- **The Vineyard runs alongside** (Guinan) - the standing weekly joy-for-its-own-sake thread; this lighter session is a natural place to let it breathe.

Care points

- This session is light and playful on purpose - it lets the room exhale after S2 and before S4. Keep it that way; do not import heavy material.

- Consequence-thinking can tip into anxiety (paralysis by "what if everything goes wrong") - always pair it with agency ("and here is the move you can still make"); the point is wiser action, not fear of acting.
- Carry the somatic open-settle and glad-close; a light session still bookends.
- Coach-not-therapist carries.

Week 10 - OPEN (every choice sends ripples)

- **Mon - Self-guided** - core / HS credits; a small choice you made that had effects you did not expect; Log. Check-in.
- **Tue - Guided (lighter)** - what-if games; the Monkey's Paw (the wish with a twist); every choice sends ripples. *Toddler-flexible.*
- **Wed - Self-guided** - core; map the ripples of one recent decision; Log. Check-in.
- **Thu - Guided (deep)** - the Ripple Board: 1st -> 2nd -> 3rd-order effects of a choice; where the intended and the unintended diverge. Bridge: pick a real decision to trace.
- **Fri - Fallow / hearth.**

Week 11 - DEEPEN (looking downstream)

- **Mon - Self-guided** - core; trace your chosen decision two and three moves out; Log. Check-in.
- **Tue - Guided (lighter)** - counterfactual history - change one thing, follow the ripples; play with the fragility of "how things turned out." *Toddler-flexible.*
- **Wed - Self-guided** - core; who is affected downstream that you had not considered? Log. Check-in.
- **Thu - Guided (deep)** - the Pre-Mortem: imagine your choice failed - why? What did the ripples do? Turn foresight into a better plan. Bridge: what would you change now?
- **Fri - Fallow / hearth.**

Week 12 - HARVEST (a decision traced forward)

- **Mon - Self-guided** - core; finalize your traced decision (ripples, blind spots, the still-available move); Log. Check-in.
- **Tue - Guided (lighter)** - share ripple-maps; the room adds effects each learner missed - consequence-thinking as a team sport. *Toddler-flexible.*
- **Wed - Self-guided** - core; a Log entry on what consequence-thinking changed for you. Check-in.

- **Thu - Guided (deep): HARVEST** - a decision traced forward, ripples named, blind spots owned, agency kept. *Empty-basket honored: "the honest finding is I cannot see far enough - so here is how I will stay humble and adjust" is real.* Bridge into Session 4 (The Stage): *"You can reason a call and trace it. Now: step into someone else's shoes and feel it."*
- **Fri - Fallow / hearth - closes Session 3.**

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Launch Pad Year 3 (The Helm) - Session 4 “The Stage” - Day by Day

Status: v0.2 working draft (fresh-eyes elevation; + Ring-1 seeds 2026-08-28) | **When:** weeks 13-18 (long session, 6 weeks) **Companions:** Year 3 studio-year plan (Helm); Helm Sessions 1-3; three-year spec (Season Three); coach-not-therapist referral pathway

The session at a glance

- **Arc:** OPEN (theatre as perspective-taking) -> DEEPEN (monologue work; archetypes as doorways; *Our Town*) -> APPLY (Forum Theatre - rehearse a hard call on your feet) -> HARVEST (a performed moment of empathy - stepping fully into another life and back out whole).
- **The thread:** *to make a hard call well you have to feel from inside the lives it touches. Theatre is the safest way to practice standing in someone else’s shoes - and the discipline of stepping back out is as important as stepping in.*
- **The material:** monologue work; archetypes as *doorways not identities* (you try a way of being on, you are not it); *Our Town* (“do any human beings ever realize life while they live it? - every, every minute?”); Forum Theatre (Boal - the audience can stop the scene and change the choice); and the de-roling ritual after every embodiment.
- **Helm rhythm:** Tue guided-lighter (theatre-as-play, improv, warm-ups - toddler-flexible), Thu guided-deep (monologue, *Our Town*, Forum Theatre). Mon/Wed self-guided; Fri fallow. The Vineyard runs alongside.
- **A note on joy (Guinan):** the theatre-as-play here is genuine delight, not only a safety warm-up - protect it as such; keep the Vineyard (joy for its own sake) distinct from the de-roling toolkit, which is safety craft.
- **Ring-1 seed (2026-08-28):** one of the three heaviest sessions - **NO harden-off here; the floor stays whole** (second adult on the *Our Town* death scene; de-roling every embodiment). Two distinct closes, kept separate: **de-roling** closes the *role* (“that wasn’t me”); the **Closing Practice** closes a real feeling the role opened (“that was me, and I carry it, and I’m still here”) - *never de-role real grief* (Guinan). Titrate the signal, not the floor.

Care points (this is one of the three heaviest sessions)

- **SECOND ADULT REQUIRED on the *Our Town* death-scene deep day** - it is the one place the season's allegory shield does not apply, because death on the stage *is* the real thing, and a grieving learner takes a direct hit. The second adult's only job is to leave with the learner who needs to leave.
- **Know which learners are grieving before the death scene runs** - a recent loss makes Emily's return a direct hit, not allegory. This is a pre-loaded judgment, written before the day, never improvised. Name a previewed exit for that scene specifically.
- **De-roling after EVERY embodiment, with a real mechanic** (K'Ehleyr) - the nervous system does not know a role is pretend; it runs the state for real. After each embodiment: say your own name, name three things true about your real life right now ("I am [name], I am 17, it is Tuesday, I have soccer after this"), physically remove the role/prop, shake out the hands, feel the floor. Not once per session - every time a body wears another life.
- **Roles are chosen, opt-out always, archetypes are doorways not identities** - no learner is assigned a role that lands wrong on them; a role can be given to the tribe only, observed rather than performed, or declined.
- **Somatic floor:** open settle -> mid-work discharge -> close return, every heavy day; pre-brief before the death scene (arrival, not ambush); battle-buddy pairing and the physical exit ramp in place before the scene opens.
- Coach-not-therapist carries; referral pathway live.

Week 13 - OPEN (theatre as perspective-taking)

- **Mon - Self-guided** - core / HS credits; whose shoes have you never stood in? Log. Check-in.
- **Tue - Guided (lighter)** - theatre warm-ups, improv, play; the body as an instrument of empathy; low-stakes, glad. *Toddler-flexible*.
- **Wed - Self-guided** - core; choose a life very different from yours to explore; Log. Check-in.
- **Thu - Guided (deep)** - perspective-taking through a first embodiment; archetypes as doorways (try it on, you are not it); the first de-roling. Bridge: find a monologue that is not yours.
- **Fri - Fallow / hearth.**

Week 14 - DEEPEN (monologue work)

- **Mon - Self-guided** - core; sit with your chosen monologue - whose voice is it? Log. Check-in.
- **Tue - Guided (lighter)** - monologue play; voice, body, intention; low-stakes read-throughs. *Toddler-flexible*.
- **Wed - Self-guided** - core; what does this character want that you have never wanted? Log. Check-in.
- **Thu - Guided (deep)** - monologue work in the room (voluntary to perform; observing is equal); step in, step out (de-role each time). Bridge: toward *Our Town*.
- **Fri - Fallow / hearth.**

Week 15 - DEEPEN (Our Town - the ordinary made holy)

- **Mon - Self-guided** - core; read the *Our Town* material; what ordinary day would you want to live again? Log. Check-in.
- **Tue - Guided (lighter)** - the play's world; the ordinary made holy; gentle, not yet the death scene. *Toddler-flexible*.
- **Wed - Self-guided** - core; notice one ordinary thing today as if for the last time; Log. Check-in.
- **Thu - Guided (deep), SECOND ADULT, pre-briefed** - Emily's return: "do any human beings ever realize life while they live it?" Hold the grief that surfaces (grief is a wave - let it move through; the second adult holds any learner who needs to step out). Full de-roling; a somatic close. Bridge: carry the ordinary-is-holy into your own life.
- **Fri - Fallow / hearth.**

Weeks 16-17 - APPLY (Forum Theatre - rehearse the hard call)

Each week, same shape: - **Mon / Wed - Self-guided** - core; script a hard-call scene (yours or invented); Log; check-in. - **Tue - Guided (lighter)** - Forum Theatre setup (Boal): the audience can stop the scene and try a different choice; play with alternatives on your feet. *Toddler-flexible*. - **Thu - Guided (deep)** - run the hard-call scenes; the room rehearses choices bodily; de-role each time. Bridge: the choice you would actually make, and why. - **Fri - Fallow / hearth.**

Week 18 - HARVEST (a performed moment of empathy)

- **Mon - Self-guided** - core; prepare your embodiment/scene; Log. Check-in.
- **Tue - Guided (lighter)** - dress the room; last warm-ups; confirm each learner's chosen level (perform / tribe-only / observe). *Toddler-flexible*.
- **Wed - Self-guided** - core; rest; final prep. Check-in.
- **Thu - Guided (deep): HARVEST** - a performed moment of empathy - stepping fully into another life and back out whole (de-roling is part of the harvest, not an afterthought). *Being seen is a gift, never a demand*. Bridge into Session 5 (The Arena of Voices): *"You have stood in others' shoes. Now: learn from those who walk the road ahead of you."*
- **Fri - Fallow / hearth - closes Session 4.**

"We evoke - we never extract."

Launch Pad Year 3 (The Helm) - Session 5 “The Arena of Voices” - Day by Day

Status: v0.2 working draft (fresh-eyes elevation; + Ring-1 seeds 2026-08-28) | **When:** weeks 19-21 (short session; mentor infrastructure precedes it - see below) **Companions:** Year 3 studio-year plan (Helm); Helm Sessions 1-4; three-year spec (Season Three)

The session at a glance

- **Arc:** OPEN (the art of being mentored) -> DEEPEN (real professional mentors + Boise guest speakers) -> HARVEST (a real conversation with someone walking the road ahead - and what it opened).
- **The thread:** *no one navigates alone. The people further down your road are a gift - and being mentored well is a skill: come prepared, ask a question worth a busy person’s time, follow up. A good question is the reciprocal gift.*
- **The work:** the art of being mentored (prepare, ask, follow up); the informational interview; a pitch (what you are building / where you are headed); Boise guest speakers who have made real hard calls.
- **Helm rhythm:** Tue guided-lighter (interview craft, pitch practice, guest speakers - toddler-flexible), Thu guided-deep (reflection on what the voices opened). Mon/Wed self-guided; Fri fallow. The Vineyard runs alongside.
- **“Learning the terrain from those who walked it” (Kirk)** - name S5’s place in the year: the mentors and guest speakers are how the captain learns the ground before the Council and the Launch.
- **Ring-1 seed (2026-08-28) - a home for the reseated harden-off.** The mentor-rejection preload (reaching out and being ignored) is exactly the kind of *ordinary-stakes, met-alone* hard thing the harden-off belongs on (reseated off the heavy material): the learner meets it with ordinary support (the preload, a debrief), discovering their own roots hold - never a manufactured wound, always gated to the ready learner and never for the already-over-hardened one (Kira). Carry the Closing Practice for what a real conversation opens.

The two-track design (BINDING - see the operating plan)

- **Guest speakers (the window):** guide present the whole visit (satisfies never-alone); public/observable setting; a short expectations sheet the speaker acknowledges; parent notification of who and when. **No background check** for a one-time supervised group

speaker - the supervision is the control. Watch the conversion point: any speaker who wants to keep contact with a learner routes follow-up through the guide (which moves them to the mentor track).

- **1:1 professional mentors (the door):** NOT cleared until the mentor infrastructure exists - observable channel only (no private DMs/social/off-platform); default remote-and-monitored, in-person only with the guide present or a public setting; **background check** before first contact; three-party informed consent (parent, learner, mentor) + signed boundaries; a no-fault off-ramp (one word to the guide ends a match, no reason owed); a written safeguarding + mandatory-reporting policy; and **counsel review** (Idaho duty-of-care + liability/insurance). Build the container before the first match.
- **Reciprocity (Kasidy):** pay real honoraria + costs (a waived fee only if freely offered); a menu of depths (one interview / a short arc / a sustained 1:1) with the one-off honored identically to the year-long; bounded terms + dignified exit; the teen arrives prepared; close the loop (thanks, tell them what their gift did, ask if it served them); **the story is a gift, never the price** (a hard call - especially a trauma-proximate one - is invited, never required as content); continuity over churn; the mentor is not the load-bearing safeguarding adult.

Care points

- **Mentor-rejection preload (Jake):** reaching out to an admired professional and being ignored is a real wound at this age. Teach *before* the outreach: “a non-response is not a verdict on you - busy people are busy.” Preloaded, not consoled after.
- Sourcing is reciprocal and warm - through communities that already hold relationship (the VL parent network, Boise professional/civic bodies, field-specific reach shaped by the learners’ own interests), never cold extraction. George costs and does outreach; Kira/Stirps if it touches refugee/immigrant communities.
- Carry the somatic settle and glad-close.
- Coach-not-therapist carries; keep the mentor boundary bright.

Week 19 - OPEN (the art of being mentored)

- **Mon - Self-guided** - core / HS credits; who is walking the road you want to walk? Log. Check-in.
- **Tue - Guided (lighter)** - the art of being mentored (prepare, ask a real question, follow up); the mentor-rejection preload; draft your interview questions. *Toddler-flexible*.
- **Wed - Self-guided** - core; research your field/person; write a question worth a busy person’s time; Log. Check-in.
- **Thu - Guided (deep)** - why we need voices ahead of us; what a good question gives the person answering it; the pitch shaped. Bridge: prepare for a real conversation.

- **Fri - Fallow / hearth.**

Week 20 - DEEPEN (the voices arrive)

- **Mon - Self-guided** - core; final prep for your informational interview / mentor conversation; Log. Check-in.
- **Tue - Guided (lighter) - GUEST SPEAKER(S)** - a Boise professional who has made real hard calls (guide present; expectations sheet acknowledged; reciprocal - they get to ask the learners too; fed at the Table). *Toddler-flexible.*
- **Wed - Self-guided** - core; conduct your informational interview (observable channel; prepared); Log. Check-in.
- **Thu - Guided (deep)** - reflect on the voices: what surprised you? What did a real hard-call story teach that a lesson could not? Bridge: what will you carry?
- **Fri - Fallow / hearth.**

Week 21 - HARVEST (a real conversation, and what it opened)

- **Mon - Self-guided** - core; write up what your mentor/interview opened; Log. Check-in.
- **Tue - Guided (lighter)** - share what the voices gave; thank the givers (notes the learners write); close the loop. *Toddler-flexible.*
- **Wed - Self-guided** - core; one next step your conversation pointed to; Log. Check-in.
- **Thu - Guided (deep): HARVEST** - a real conversation with someone ahead of you, and the honest account of what it opened (or did not). *Empty-basket honored: "the interview did not land, and here is what I learned about reaching out" is real.* Bridge into Session 6 (The Bridge): *"You have learned from those who lead. Now: practice leading - and being led."*
- **Fri - Fallow / hearth - closes Session 5.**

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Launch Pad Year 3 (The Helm) - Session 6 “The Bridge” - Day by Day

Status: v0.2 working draft (fresh-eyes elevation; + Ring-1 seeds 2026-08-28) | **When:** weeks 22-24 (short session) **Companions:** Year 3 studio-year plan (Helm); Helm Sessions 1-5; three-year spec (Season Three)

The session at a glance

- **Arc:** OPEN (what leadership actually is) -> DEEPEN (rotating command AND rotating facilitation; find-your-style; the hard parts) -> HARVEST (a real act of leading peers - and of being led).
- **The thread:** *leadership is stewardship, not command. The best captains lead toward their own unnecessity - they build a crew that no longer needs them. You practice both seats: leading, and being led well.*
- **This is where the Mantle is worn (Bareil)** - the mantle taken up in S1 is now tested in the chair: you lead, you are led, you learn what the weight actually feels like. Literally put it on when you take the chair.
- **The work:** rotating command (everyone takes the chair); **rotating facilitation (Curzon) - the different, nearly opposite skill S7 needs;** find-your-captain-style; leadership as service; the hard parts; honoring the quiet leaders (leadership is not volume).
- **Feeds S7 directly (Curzon):** command teaches you to sit in the chair and decide; *facilitation* teaches you to hold the room from beside it, refusing to decide so the group can. The Council needs the second, so S6 must build it.
- **Ring-1 seed (2026-08-28) - a home for the reseated harden-off.** Leading peers through a real disagreement (rotating facilitation, the hard parts) is an ordinary-stakes, met-with-ordinary-support challenge - a fitting home for the reseated harden-off (off the heavy material): the learner holds the room with the guide nearby, not hovering, and discovers their roots hold. Gated to the ready learner. Carry the Closing Practice.
- **The loneliness of command (Kirk):** name what no one warns you about - when the hard call comes, you make it *alone*; the crew can advise, the crew cannot decide. And its answer: the captain who has a life to go home to (the vineyard, the crew you love) makes better hard calls than the captain who has only the chair.
- **Helm rhythm:** Tue guided-lighter (leadership games, rotating command, expedition leadership - toddler-flexible), Thu guided-deep (the hard parts; stewardship; rotating facilitation). Mon/Wed self-guided; Fri fallow. The Vineyard runs alongside.
- **Collaborative and safe by design** - no second adult needed.

Care points

- **Leadership is stewardship, not dominance** - guard against the room rewarding the loudest; name and honor the quiet leaders (the one who makes others better, the one who notices who is left out).
- **Being led is a skill too** - a learner who only ever leads has not finished the lesson; rotate genuinely.
- **The hard parts are held, not performed** - disappointing someone, holding an unpopular call, being disagreed with; coach the internal weight, not the optics.
- **Mixed-age care:** do not let the graduating captains' weight set a ceiling the younger learners measure against; every seat in the chair is honored equally.
- Carry the somatic settle and glad-close. Coach-not-therapist carries.

Week 22 - OPEN (what leadership actually is)

- **Mon - Self-guided** - core / HS credits; a leader who changed something for you - what did they actually do? Log. Check-in.
- **Tue - Guided (lighter)** - leadership games; command vs stewardship; "lead toward your own unnecessity"; rotating command introduced. *Toddler-flexible.*
- **Wed - Self-guided** - core; when have you led? When have you been led well? Log. Check-in.
- **Thu - Guided (deep)** - leadership as service; the crew that no longer needs you as the goal, not a loss. Bridge: take the chair this week.
- **Fri - Fallow / hearth.**

Week 23 - DEEPEN (find your style; the hard parts)

- **Mon - Self-guided** - core; take a turn leading a peer task; notice your instincts; Log. Check-in.
- **Tue - Guided (lighter)** - find-your-captain-style (which captain do you lead like?); expedition leadership - plan and lead a real outing together. *Toddler-flexible.*
- **Wed - Self-guided** - core; a time leading asked something hard of you; Log. Check-in.
- **Thu - Guided (deep)** - the hard parts: the loneliness of the final call (yours alone to make); disappointing someone; being disagreed with; honoring the quiet leaders. **Rotating facilitation:** each learner takes the convener's chair for a low-stakes *real* cohort disagreement and practices holding the question without answering it (debriefed warmly - "here's the moment you reached for the answer when your job was to hold the question"). Bridge: what kind of captain are you becoming?
- **Fri - Fallow / hearth.**

Week 24 - HARVEST (leading, and being led)

- **Mon - Self-guided** - core; prepare your real act of leading (a task, a project, an outing); Log. Check-in.
- **Tue - Guided (lighter)** - the cohort runs a self-led challenge; every learner takes a seat (lead or be led, both honored). *Toddler-flexible.*
- **Wed - Self-guided** - core; reflect: what did leading teach that being led did not, and the reverse? Log. Check-in.
- **Thu - Guided (deep): HARVEST** - a real act of leading peers *and* of being led well - the two seats, both honored. *Empty-basket honored: "I found I lead best quietly, from beside not in front" is a real finding, not a lesser one.* Bridge into Session 7 (The Council): *"You can reason, empathize, and lead. Now: make a hard call in the open, before your people."*
- **Fri - Fallow / hearth - closes Session 6.**

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Launch Pad Year 3 (The Helm) - Session 7 “The Council” - Day by Day

Status: v0.2 working draft (fresh-eyes elevation; + Ring-1 seeds 2026-08-28) | **When:** weeks 25-30 (long session, 6 weeks; the year’s - and the arc’s - harvest) **Companions:** Year 3 studio-year plan (Helm); Helm Sessions 1-6; three-year spec (Season Three); coach-not-therapist referral pathway

The session at a glance

- **Arc:** OPEN (a council is not a debate) -> DEEPEN (the deliberative form; reason from principle; name the cost; honor dissent; the Third Chair) -> APPLY (build and rehearse the deliberation) -> HARVEST (a public Council on a real dilemma, before a warm audience).
- **The thread:** *a council is not a debate to win. It is people of good faith reasoning together toward the best hard call - naming the cost, honoring the dissent, and, when the choice is a false binary, refusing it to find the third option; and when the binary is real, choosing from principle and carrying the cost.*
- **This is the mountain the whole year climbed toward (Kirk)** - named on day one, and here it is. The learner wears the Mantle to hold the room (Bareil).
- **The Kobayashi Maru at full power (Kirk + Curzon):** the Council must contain *both* kinds of dilemma - at least one with a real third option (find it: skill) **and at least one genuinely no-win** (every path costs something you cannot get back; the harvest is reasoning honestly to a hard call and carrying its weight without self-deceiving). Half the wisdom is the third door; the other half is knowing when there isn’t one and choosing anyway, eyes open. This reconciles S2 (sit in the unwinnable) with S7 (find the third option) - they are two halves, not a contradiction.
- **The exhibition IS the reasoning, not a verdict to be judged.** The Vineyard runs alongside all six weeks.
- **Ring-1 seed (2026-08-28) - the arc-scale close.** One of the three heaviest sessions - **NO harden-off; the floor stays whole** (second adult, the somatic Council floor). This is where the Closing Practice reaches its **arc-scale culmination**: the public Council is an opening onto the social plane that needs its private re-crossing, and the Launch rite’s Separation -> Liminality -> Reincorporation *is* the three-prompt practice made into a ceremony for the whole three years. The graduate carries the practice out the door - the capacity to close their own openings, for life, is the deepest thing the Helm hands them.

- **Helm rhythm:** Tue guided-lighter (council craft, deliberation games, rehearsal in the tribe - toddler-flexible), Thu guided-deep (the Socratic shaping of the real deliberation). Mon/Wed self-guided; Fri fallow.

The Council as a real deliberative form (Curzon) - build the form, or it becomes debate

"They deliberate publicly" is a hope, not a container. Without a form, teenagers in front of an audience default to what school rehearsed: debate to win. The form: - **Named, rotating roles:** *convener* (holds the question, not a position), *voices* (argue the live positions in good faith), *scribe* (writes the reasoning where the room can see it), and the **steward of the absent** ("who is affected by this who is not in the room?" - the decision measured at its margins). - **A six-phase sequence:** Frame -> Divergence (surface every position and the fear under it, *before* arguing) -> **Steelman** -> the Cost Ledger (every path's cost and who pays, on the board) -> the Turn (real binary or false? - the Third Chair) -> the Sense of the Room (where the reasoning arrived, and where it honestly did not). - **The Steelman, mandatory and physical:** you may not argue your own position until you have voiced the best version of the one you reject, well enough that its holder says "yes, that's it." This is how honoring dissent is built into the bones (Forum Theatre from S4 pays off here). - **The Third Chair (the false-binary move, made teachable):** an empty chair between hardened sides; four questions - what is each side protecting? is the "or" real or inherited? what would honor *both* values at once? and, when there is no third option, choose from principle and carry the grief honestly. - **A scribe and a board (the load-bearing hook):** the reasoning written where all can see becomes the object in the room, not the performers. **The strongest unresolved dissent is read into the record in the dissenter's own words and left standing, unrefuted, as part of the harvest.** - **Consecrate and release (Bareil):** a marked opening ("this is not ordinary talk"), and a **closing that completes the council without resolving the dilemma** ("we did not solve it; we reasoned honestly, together, in front of our people; the council is closed") - so a young person can carry an unresolved hard thing without it becoming an open wound. - **Real stakes without a verdict (Kirk):** the Council deliberates something with actual consequence to Vibrant Life or Boise - a real policy or trade-off the community faces - so the reasoning matters because it is *used*, not *graded*.

Care points (this is one of the three heaviest sessions)

- **SECOND ADULT REQUIRED on the deep days of the real deliberation and the public Council** - public moral deliberation is exposure on exposure; the second adult holds any learner who needs to step out.

- **The dilemma is allegorical/external, never personal** - the Council deliberates a real moral question (a case, a policy, a historical hard call), never a learner's own life. No forced self-disclosure.
- **The Council that cannot be failed, somatically (K'Ehleyr):**
    - a **pass signal** (a word or gesture that returns the floor with zero cost) - freeze is an autonomic state, not a choice; make it safe;
    - **ground-before-you-speak** taught as the captain's own craft (feet on the floor, one breath) - regulation as competence, not remediation;
    - the audience is **witness, not judge** - brief the witnesses; a room of warm faces is co-regulation at scale;
    - the **feast is the come-down** - protect it as the discharge, not one more thing to get right (eating together, in company, is the body's signal that the danger is over).
- **Somatic floor:** open settle -> mid-work discharge -> close return; pre-brief before the Council; battle-buddy pairing and the physical exit ramp in place.
- Coach-not-therapist carries; referral pathway live.

Week 25 - OPEN (a council is not a debate)

- **Mon - Self-guided** - core / HS credits; a hard question your community faces with no clean answer; Log. Check-in.
- **Tue - Guided (lighter)** - what a council is (vs a debate); reasoning together, not winning; the roles introduced (convener / voices / scribe / steward of the absent); the cohort chooses the real dilemma(s) it will deliberate - **at least one with a possible third option and at least one genuinely no-win.** *Toddler-flexible.*
- **Wed - Self-guided** - core; research the chosen dilemma; where do you land, and why? Log. Check-in.
- **Thu - Guided (deep)** - the six-phase sequence walked; reason from principle; name the cost of every path; the scribe and the board (make the reasoning visible). Bridge: come ready to steelman the view you disagree with.
- **Fri - Fallow / hearth.**

Week 26 - DEEPEN (the Third Chair - and the no-win call)

- **Mon - Self-guided** - core; is the dilemma a true binary, or a false one? Log. Check-in.
- **Tue - Guided (lighter)** - deliberation games; the **mandatory Steelman** rehearsed; the **Third Chair** (the four questions) for the false-binary dilemma. *Toddler-flexible.*
- **Wed - Self-guided** - core; draft your principled position (principle, cost, dissent honored, third option if any); Log. Check-in.

- **Thu - Guided (deep)** - the *genuinely no-win* case: when there is no third door, choose from principle, name the cost, and do not lose yourself carrying it (the Kobayashi Maru at full power). Shape the deliberation; where it reasons well, where it collapses into debate. Bridge: toward a full run.
- **Fri - Fallow / hearth.**

Weeks 27-28 - APPLY (build and rehearse the deliberation)

Each week, same shape: - **Mon / Wed - Self-guided** - core; refine your reasoning and role in the Council; Log; check-in. - **Tue - Guided (lighter)** - council-craft; ground-before-you-speak practice; the pass signal rehearsed; low-stakes run-throughs. *Toddler-flexible.* - **Thu - Guided (deep)** - full rehearsal in the tribe's safety; the guide holds reasoning over performance; hold nerves warmly. Bridge: toward the public Council. - **Fri - Fallow / hearth.**

Week 29 - APPLY (final rehearsal; set the room)

- **Mon - Self-guided** - core; polish your part / chosen role (full Council / smaller role / witness - each honored); Log. Check-in.
- **Tue - Guided (lighter)** - dry-run; confirm each learner's chosen level; brief the witness-audience (witness, not judge). *Toddler-flexible.*
- **Wed - Self-guided** - core; a Log entry on the year and the arc; rest. Check-in.
- **Thu - Guided (deep), SECOND ADULT** - final dry-run; ground the room; the pass signal and exit ramp confirmed; the feast planned as the come-down. Bridge: rest before the Council.
- **Fri - Fallow / hearth.**

Week 30 - HARVEST (the public Council + feast)

- **Mon - Self-guided** - core; final touches; rest. Check-in.
- **Tue - Guided (lighter)** - set the room for the Council and feast; last nerves held. *Toddler-flexible.*
- **Wed - Self-guided** - final prep; rest. Check-in.
- **Thu - THE COUNCIL + FEAST, SECOND ADULT** - a **consecrated opening** ("this is not ordinary talk"); the six-phase deliberation of a real dilemma before a warm witness-audience: roles held, reason from principle, the mandatory steelman, the cost ledger on the board, the Third Chair where the binary is false - and, on the no-win case, a hard call made from principle with its cost named. The strongest dissent is read into the record and left standing. **A closing that completes the council without resolving the dilemma** ("we did not solve it; we reasoned honestly, together; the council is closed").

The exhibition is the reasoning, never a verdict; a learner may pass, pause, or come back with zero cost. The feast is the come-down and the celebration. This is The Helm's harvest.
- **Fri - Fallow / hearth - closes Session 7 and the Helm year.**

The year-close and the Launch (carry the operating plan)

Before the next season - or, for a graduating captain, before the Launch: a **co-authoring close** (the learner reviews the year's design *with* the guide - "here is how The Helm was built, and why; tell me what to change") and a **Captain's Log ownership handoff** ("it is yours; take it; no copy kept").

For the founding cohort completing the cycle - the Next Great Adventure (the Launch), built as a true rite of passage (Bareil + Guinan + Ezri):

- **SEPARATION (the un-belonging):** guide opens the rite (never the system) -> look back and read the Growth Record together (arrive at where you have been) -> **the grief-and-gratitude beat** as the *work* of this phase (the ending named directly - "this was your home; you are being released from it" - allowed to be sad, held, unrushed, with a real exit). *Do not de-role this grief* - it is stepping out of a self that truly was you, not a role that never was.
- **LIMINALITY (the threshold, held):** the Dome opens; the **Star Chart given as a threshold-object in a silence no one fills** - the map of where they have been, handed at the moment they must navigate by it alone -> craft the next-step document.
- **REINCORPORATION (the crossing, witnessed, with a change of standing): the handoff** (generate the Growth Record Portrait export, choose its visibility, take it - this beat cannot be ceremony over a placeholder; the v1 export must be real) + the **Captain's Log** handed over ("it is yours; no copy kept") + the **Mantle keep-or-leave** choice (either true; the choosing is the rite) + **leaving a gift for the room** (a word to the next captain, a mark, their Vineyard-thing - for the founding cohort, the room's first inheritance) + a **witnessed crossing** over a literal threshold into a circle of adults who receive them *as an adult and address them differently on the far side* -> the Launch (the door closes and stays unlocked from her side; no come-back nudge).

The cohort marks the departure *as a cohort* (not the guide performing it at them). **The family-less learner is named and held** - the tribe is *your people*, said in advance, the inclusion floor applied to the most tender day of nine years. The learner walks out holding three things: the Growth Record (backward face), the next-step document (forward face), and the Captain's Log (their private voice). *The arc completes.*

"We evoke - we never extract."

NOTES